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Trump ups tariff to 15%, a day after levying 10% post SC ruling

TARIFF RESET. Commerce Dept studying implications; no change in trade deal with India: Trump

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The US reciprocal tariffs of 18 per cent on Indian goods, established under the framework India-US interim trade deal, have been invalidated following a Friday ruling by the US Supreme Court striking down President Donald Trump's "illegal" tariffs. In their place, goods will now be subject to a 15 per cent "world-wide tariff", Trump posted on his social media platform *TruthSocial* on Saturday. He raised the tariffs from 10 per cent, imposed as a "temporary" levy on Friday on all imports for a period of 150 days.

"We have noted the US Supreme Court judgment on tariffs yesterday. President Trump has also addressed a press conference in that regard. Some steps have been announced by the US administration. We are studying all these developments for their implications," per a statement from the Commerce Department.

While Indian exporters are relieved by the drop in additional tariffs to 15 per cent, the uncertainty on the steps the Trump administration may take is a point of concern.

"The February export numbers to the US are encouraging so far (following announcement of US tariff reduction to 18 per cent by Trump on Feb 2). A further reduction now should be good for exports. But it is still uncertain how Trump will actually react to the judgment," said Ajay Sahai from exporters' body FIEO.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- US reciprocal tariffs of 18/25% on Indian textiles, leather, etc invalidated by US Supreme Court
- A 15% temporary surcharge levied by Trump regime on most imports from Feb 24 for 150 days
- Certain items exempted such as minerals, some fertilisers and agri, pharma, automobiles
- Section 232 tariffs of 50% on steel and aluminium remain unchanged
- Exporters welcome lower tariff but flag uncertainty over Trump's next steps
- Trade experts say India must leverage the development to negotiate a better trade deal

Trump announced on *TruthSocial* that he was raising the 10 per cent rate to 15 per cent—the maximum level permitted under Section 122—stating that trading partners had been "ripping off" the US for decades.

Effectively, reciprocal tariffs of 25 per cent on Indian labour-intensive goods such as textiles, leather and shrimp, which were to be reduced to 18 per cent under the deal, now face a levy of 15 per cent, the same as most other countries trading with the US.

However, the Section 232 tariff of 50 per cent on steel and aluminium remain unchanged, as they were not covered by the top court's ruling.

IMPROVED LEVERAGE

Despite Trump's assertion that "nothing changes" and that India will continue to pay tariffs, trade experts say the ruling strengthens Delhi's negotiating position in ongoing bilateral talks.

Sensitive areas include agriculture market access, digital trade rules and India's policy autonomy in dealing with so-called non-market economies such as China.

UNRESOLVED ISSUES

"There are a lot of issues in the India-US trade agreement that

are delicate and have not been agreed to yet. These include market access for cereals and dairy, digital trade, the country's position on Russian oil and its relationship with China. India must now stay firm on not giving concessions on its sensitivities," trade expert Biswajit Dhar said.

The ruling should prompt India to re-examine its trade deal with the US, said Ajay Srivastava of GTRI.

While Trump has said he will re-impose similar tariffs on trade partners under other sections such as Section 301 and Section 232 that have not been struck down, Srivastava said that it would take time as there would be new investigations and public justifications have to be given.

Dhar said the replacement tariffs that Trump would now work on will not be sweeping and have to be product-specific.

Illinois Governor demands \$8.7 b refund, threatens further action

Press Trust of India

The US Supreme Court has set off a debate on the money already collected by the US government. According to trade lawyers, importers are likely to get back the money.

There has been a precedent when in the 1990s the courts struck down a port fee and set up a refund system for exporters.

Illinois Governor JB Pritzker, a Democrat and

Trump antagonist, is demanding a refund on behalf of his State's 5.11 million households. In a letter addressed to Trump and released by Pritzker's gubernatorial campaign, the Governor said the tariffs had cost each Illinois household \$1,700 — or \$8.7 billion. Pritzker said failure to pay will elicit "further action."

Nevada Treasurer Zach Conine submitted a payment request to the federal government for \$2.1 billion.

Pact on rare minerals tops MoUs signed by PM, Brazil President Lula

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Brazil and India will work to strengthen bilateral relations and the Global South to avoid facing a US-China cold war, said Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, even as Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed confidence that India-Brazil annual bilateral trade will surpass \$20 billion (from \$15 billion) in five years, noting that the growth was a reflection of mutual trust.

The two countries signed/announced a total of ten agreements and MoUs, including ones on critical minerals and rare earths, digital partnership, traditional knowledge digital library, MSME entrepreneurship, mining and steel, and health and pharmaceuticals.

An announcement by Brazil on extension of business visa for Indians to ten years, from five, was also made. (This came to effect from February 7.)

STRENGTHENING SOUTH

"The eyes of Brazil towards India are very hopeful... If we work together, we are going to strengthen Brazil-India bilateral relations... We're going to strengthen the Global South so that we never ever again are faced with a cold war between two big superpowers," Lula said alluding to China and the US in the joint press briefing with Modi following their bilateral meeting on Saturday.

Lula also said that the coming together of India and Brazil was "a meeting of the world's pharmacy with the



President Droupadi Murmu and PM Narendra Modi with Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, at a ceremonial reception at Rashtrapati Bhavan on Saturday **ANI**

world's barn and a digital superpower with a renewable energy superpower." Both the countries defended multilateralism and peace, he said.

TRADING PARTNERS

Modi pointed out that Brazil was India's largest trading partner in Latin America and the two had discussed moving ahead with a shared purpose and shared aspirations in multiple areas.

"We are committed to taking bilateral trade beyond \$20 billion in five years. Our trade is not just a number, it is a reflection of our mutual trust," Modi said in his statement.

The large business delegation accompanying the Brazilian President also signals the trust between the two countries, he said.

UN REFORMS

The joint statement issued by the two leaders stressed on the need for UN reforms and Lula explicitly backed India for a permanent seat on the Security Council. "We are going to continue to fight

for the UN to be more representative with more countries throughout the world and (push for) Brazil and India as members of the Permanent Security Council..." he said.

SUPPLY CHAINS

The agreements and MoUs signed by India and Brazil focus on strategic, high-tech, and sustainable sectors that could bolster the Global South alliance.

"The agreement on critical minerals and rare earths is a decisive step towards building resilient supply chains," Modi said. Brazil holds world's one of the largest reserves of these minerals, which are vital for EVs, smartphones, and defence applications. An effective alliance with Brazil will reduce India's dependence on supplies from China.

A dedicated MoU was signed focussing on establishing a Centre of Excellence for digital public infrastructure in Brazil and collaboration on AI, supercomputers, semiconductors, and blockchain.

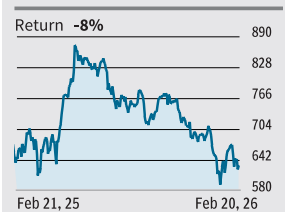
INVESTMENT. FOCUS

DLF — Accumulate

Venkatasubramanian K
bl. research bureau

Large real estate players that operate in the premium residential segment, along with commercial leasing and office parks spaces, have been resilient during the relatively moderate to low-growth phases witnessed in the realty sector over the past 12-18 months. DLF is one such key leading player.

From the highs of ₹920 made in March 2024, the stock of DLF has done time and price corrections over the past couple of years.



At ₹629, the stock trades at 32 times its likely per share earnings for FY27. On a price to book basis, the multiple comes to a little over three times.

On a relative basis, compared to historical valuations, DLF provides a reasonable opportunity for long-term investors.

Investors with a perspective of more than three years can consider accumulating the stock at present levels and on declines linked to the broader market.

USFDA clears Dr Reddy's licence application for arthritis biosimilar drug Orencia

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The US Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) has approved a Biologics Licence Application (BLA) for a proposed biosimilar to Orencia (Abatacept).

The company's 351 (k) Biologics Licence Application (BLA) IV for infusion formulation for DRL-AB, for the proposed interchangeable biosimilar was submitted in December.

"We are proud to be the first to submit a BLA for an Abatacept biosimilar which marks a significant milestone in our mission to increase patient access to critical, high-quality biologic therapies," Milan Kalawadia, CEO, North America, Dr. Reddy's, said in a release on Saturday.

WHO WILL BENEFIT

DRL-AB, once approved, will be administered as an IV for infusion formulation for the treatment of adults with moderately-to-severely active rheumatoid arthritis, adults with active psoriatic arthritis, and individuals aged six years and above with moderately-to-severely active polyarticular juvenile idiopathic arthritis.

The Hyderabad-based pharma major's application included a comprehensive data package consisting of analytical, pharmacokinetic, and clinical studies.

88 countries including US, China endorse AI Summit Declaration 'for benefit of all'

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The New Delhi Declaration on AI Impact, has been endorsed by 88 countries including the US, the UK, Brazil, Australia, Austria, China, Canada and Switzerland.

The Declaration reflects a broad-based global consensus on leveraging Artificial Intelligence for economic growth and social good, strengthening international cooperation and multi-stakeholder engagement, respecting national sovereignty, advancing AI through accessible, and trustworthy frameworks, the

government said on Saturday.

"We take note of the 'Charter for the Democratic Diffusion of AI' as a voluntary and non-binding framework to promote access to foundational AI resources, support locally relevant innovation, and strengthen resilient AI ecosystems while respecting national laws," the endorsement said.

SEVEN AREAS

The Declaration is structured around seven key pillars or seven 'Chakras' forming the foundation of global AI cooperation including democratising AI resources; economic growth & social good; secure & trusted AI; AI

for Science; access for social empowerment; human capital development resilient; and efficient & innovative AI systems.

"Guided by the principle of 'Sarvajana Hitaya, Sarvajana Sukhaya' (Welfare for all, Happiness for all), the Declaration underscores that the benefits of AI must be equitably shared across humanity," the Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) said.

MeitY said the participants reaffirmed their commitment to advancing shared global priorities in AI governance; promoting voluntary, non-binding frameworks, and translating vision into action through contin-

ued collaboration.

GLOBAL FOCUS

At the heart of the declaration is a push to broaden access to foundational AI capabilities, particularly for developing economies. Citing the civilisational ethos of *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*, the document underscores that "AI's promise is best realised only when its benefits are shared by humanity."

The approach marks a calibrated stance in the global AI debate, where some jurisdictions are moving towards stricter regulatory architectures while others argue that over-regulation could stifle innovation and widen the digital divide.

NSE trading speed to hit nanoseconds from Apr 11

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Indian capital markets will shift to nanosecond-level response times in equities and equity derivatives from April 11, making domestic markets nearly 1,000 times faster than some of the world's fastest trading platforms, said Ashish Chauhan, MD and CEO of the National Stock Exchange of India.

Speaking at the Association of National Exchange Members of India's Stock-Tech event, Chauhan said the NSE's currency derivatives segment already operates at nanosecond speeds

and equities will soon follow. "In less than two months, our response time in equities and equity derivatives will move to nanoseconds. One second equals 100 crore nanoseconds," he said.

In trading terms, response time is the period taken by exchange systems to receive, process and confirm an order.

Lower latency enables faster order matching, sharper price discovery and near real-time risk management — increasingly critical as algorithmic and high-frequency trading volumes grow.

The exchange is also scal-

ing up order-handling capacity to 10 crore transactions per second, from about 50-60 lakh currently.

To support higher volumes, the NSE is expanding its co-location infrastructure, with capacity set to rise two to three times.

COMPLIANCE, AI PUSH

Chauhan said the technology overhaul is aligned with compliance under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, which will affect the entire market ecosystem. As trading speeds increase, cybersecurity and tighter system integration will become critical.

The exchange is also developing agentic artificial intelligence in collaboration with a leading global university and has urged technology providers to use AI to reduce costs and improve efficiency. "Stock markets are real-time finance. India pioneered technology-led trading 32 years ago and must continue to stay ahead," he said.

Paul Ghosh, Director of Market Operations at NSE, described the move to nanosecond response time as a fundamental shift that would enhance reliability and scalability for all market participants.

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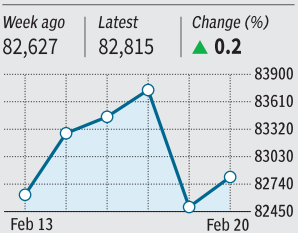
WISE WORDS.

“ Games are won by players who focus on the playing field – not by those whose eyes are glued to the scoreboard.

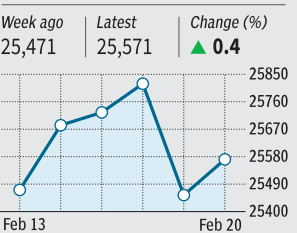
WARREN BUFFETT

MARKET ACTION.

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RARE ELEMENTS THAT POWER THE FUTURE

MINE TO MAGNET. With rare earth materials, the real leverage is strategic, not size. Here is a lowdown on the entire ecosystem and what makes them so critical to today’s industrial landscape and for India



GETTY IMAGES

Kumar Shankar Roy
bl, research bureau

At the recently-concluded India AI Impact Summit in New Delhi this week, CEOs Sam Altman, Sundar Pichai, Demis Hassabis and Dario Amodei took centre stage. The spotlight, though, was on the same stack: AI models, chips and data centres, the machinery behind ChatGPT, Gemini, DeepSeek and Claude, typically powered by Nvidia GPUs. But AI needs a physical system. It must store data, move parts with microscopic precision and cool power-hungry servers. That is where rare earth elements (REEs) enter the scene, mainly through permanent magnets, which retain magnetism without continuous external power. Neodymium magnets also sit inside the high-efficiency motors that keep data centres running, powering fans, pumps and compressors that move air and chilled water/coolant with precision. As AI is increasingly embedded in robots and automation, this magnet dependence only grows. The same rare earth magnets sit inside EV motors (from BYD, Tesla and many other mass-market EV makers), wind turbines from manufacturers such as Siemens Gamesa and Vestas and industrial robots from ABB and KUKA. They are also in defence systems such as radar and guidance components.

REEs may not be visible to consumers like gold or silver, but they are embedded deep inside modern machinery. The oddity is economic in nature. Global rare earth output is large in tonnage at 390,000 tonnes, yet small in headline market value at less than \$7 billion (industry estimates), because the real leverage is strategic, not size. Production is heavily concentrated. China dominates mining, but its real leverage lies in processing and separation, where various estimates put its share of global capacity at around 90 per cent, leaving it at the choke point between ore and magnets. When export controls were tightened by the country last year, it showed how fast supply chains can choke, sending automobile firms scrambling for supplies.

That is one of the many reasons why countries are building mine-to-magnet capacity at home using stakes, funding and offtakes, and why India (the world’s third-largest reserves of rare earths at 6.9 million tonnes), is pushing a critical minerals mission to avoid staying only a buyer in someone else’s supply system. Governments around the world are no longer treating rare earths like a normal commodity. In the US, policy has turned openly strategic, including under Donald Trump, with support for domestic mines, stockpiles and overseas sourcing to reduce dependence on China. The race is also widening the map and the capital pool. Greenland is often cited for large deposits. Kenya’s Mrima Hill, reportedly holding over 40 million tonnes of rare earth-bearing ore resources, has made headlines. Ukraine features in the broader critical-minerals narrative. Hence, rare earths as a topic keep resurfacing in policy and boardrooms.

First, the basics.

WHAT THEY ARE

REEs are a group of 17 chemical elements. They include 15 closely-related metals called lanthanides, such as neodymium and dysprosium, which are used to make high-strength magnets. Scandium and yttrium are also grouped together with lanthanides because they occur in the same deposits and share similar chemical behaviour. The ‘rare’ in rare earth metals is something of a misnomer. “Rare earth elements is a terrible name because they’re everywhere; they’re not rare at all,” as US Energy Secretary Chris Wright puts it. In fact, cerium is roughly as abundant as, say, copper, in the Earth’s crust. What makes them economically rare is that they’re dispersed in low concentrations, often occurring at just a few grams per tonne of rock. They are also chemically difficult to separate, as sorting often involves hundreds of stages to isolate individual rare earths.

Historically, REEs were first discovered in 1787 in a small village called Ytterby in Sweden, where miners found an unusual black mineral that led to the identification of

several new metals over the next century. For much of the 20th century, rare earth production was led by the US, especially from the Mountain Pass mine in California. The desert open-pit rare-earth mine in California’s Mojave was at one point supplying 70 per cent of global rare earths until the early 1980s. From the 1980s, China under Deng Xiaoping’s reform-era leadership invested heavily in mining and, more importantly, in the complex chemical processing needed to separate these metals. From the 1990s, US production continued to decline. Over time, lower costs, including cheap labour and relaxed environmental standards, and State support helped China build dominance across the rare earth supply chain. This turned what was once a niche scientific curiosity into a strategically-important industrial resource today.

Make no mistake, not all rare earths are equally valuable. Rare earths rarely trade as pure metals; they are typically processed and priced first as oxides, which are then converted into metals and magnet alloys. Recent benchmark quotes show lanthanum oxide selling in the low single-digit dollars per kg, while neodymium oxide trades in the low-\$100s per kg. Dysprosium, used in smaller volumes but critical for high-temperature magnets, trades at a large premium because it is a heavy rare earth. This wide dispersion in value is important. A handful of elements such as neodymium, praseodymium and dysprosium drive most of the industry’s economics, largely because they are used to make permanent magnets.

But these metals do not come out of the ground as neat, tradable powders. They start as messy rocks and sands, and the real story begins with where they are found and how they are separated.

DECODING VALUE CHAIN

In rare earths, mining gets the headlines, separation is the moat, but magnets are the prize. To understand where the money is made, follow the rare earth value chain.

Mining is only the first step. Rare earth ores such as bastnäsite, monazite or ion-adsorption clays are extracted from the ground. These ores are then concentrated and chemically processed to produce rare earth oxides (REOs). Processing can cost several times more than mining. Oxides are refined further into metals or alloys. Those alloys are then used to manufacture high-strength permanent magnets. Finally, magnets are built into motors, turbines and electronic components.

At each stage, value increases. A tonne of ore has relatively low economic value. But a

How REEs stack up geographically

Country	Mine production 2025 (tonnes)	Reserves (tonnes)
United States	51,000	1,900,000
Australia	29,000	6,300,000
Brazil	2,000	21,000,000
Burma	22,000	NA
Canada	—	830,000
China	270,000	44,000,000
Greenland	—	1,500,000
India	2,900	6,900,000
Madagascar	2,700	NA
Malaysia	110	710,000
Nigeria	1,500	NA
Russia	2,600	3,800,000
South Africa	—	860,000
Tanzania	—	890,000
Thailand	4,800	NA
Vietnam	150	3,500,000

Source: U.S. Geological Survey

back-of-the-envelope calculation shows a tonne of separated neodymium oxide can be roughly 3,500 times the value of a tonne of ore. Finished Neodymium-Iron-Boron magnet material typically sits around 1,600-2,200 times the ore value and can be higher for premium grades. According to US Geological Survey data, magnets are the largest rare earth end-use globally, followed by catalysts and polishing; other applications span metallurgy/alloys, ceramics, glass, phosphors and pigments. This explains why control over processing and magnet manufacturing carries more economic weight than mining alone. The chemistry involved in separating rare earths is complex, capital intensive and environmentally sensitive. Solvent extraction plants require technical expertise built over decades. That processing capability has become the real bottleneck in the supply chain.

China controls this bottleneck. Of the total global rare earth production, China accounts for roughly 270,000 tonnes. The US is at 51,000 tonnes. Australia is at 29,000 tonnes, while India produces just about 2,900 tonnes. The headline number often quoted is China’s

share of mining, but its stronger position lies in refining and downstream conversion. China controls the overwhelming majority of rare earth separation capacity and magnet production. Even when REO is mined in other countries, it is frequently shipped to China for processing. And, supply risk quickly translates into price volatility.

In response, other countries have begun building alternative supply chains. The US has moved beyond policy statements into direct capital deployment. In 2025, the US Department of Defense (DoD) invested \$400 million in MP Materials, alongside a \$150-million DoD loan to expand heavy rare-earth separation at Mountain Pass and plans tied to scaling magnet capacity. In 2026, the US also agreed to take a 10 per cent stake in USA Rare Earth as part of a reported \$1.6-billion debt-and-equity package. Japan has used its State-backed financing ecosystem to lock in non-China supply. State entity JOGMEC and conglomerate Sojitz have repeatedly supported Lynas (Australia) to secure rare earth supply to Japanese industry, including equity-style support routed through the Japan-Australia Rare Earths (JARE) structure for Lynas’ expansion and heavy rare-earth capability. Australia’s role is anchored by Lynas Rare Earths, widely cited as the largest producer outside China. It is increasingly linked into allied supply chains via Japan (Sojitz/JOGMEC) and the US. Europe’s approach is a mix of regulation, project fast-tracking and industrial capacity. The EU Critical Raw Materials Act is being operationalised via a first list of 47 “Strategic Projects” intended to accelerate permitting and improve access to finance across extraction, processing and recycling. Canada is explicitly building midstream capability rather than only mining. The Saskatchewan Research Council (SRC) has been scaling a rare-earth processing and metals capability in Saskatoon (government-backed), aiming to produce NdPr (Neodymium-Praseodymium) metals at high purity and ramp monthly output. Brazil is emerging as a key “outside-China” source, particularly for heavy rare-earth-rich output, with explicit US backing. In February 2026, a \$565-million financing from the US International Development Finance Corp to rare earth producer Serra Verde included an option for US to take a minority equity stake; Serra Verde achieved commercial production in 2024.

INDIA’S POSITION

India sits in a paradoxical spot in the rare earths supply chain (see table). It has meaningful geology, but limited industrial depth.

India holds about 6 per cent of global rare earth reserves, with deposits concentrated in shoreline areas of Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra and Gujarat, and exploration activity also visible in Rajasthan. Yet, India contributes less than 1 per cent of global REE mining. The import dependence is even sharper in magnets: India imports an estimated 80 to 90 per cent of magnets and related materials from China. Demand is rising fast. India’s consumption of rare earth permanent magnets is expected to double by 2030.

Policy response has accelerated in recent times, with magnets as the near-term focal point. In November 2025, the Union Cabinet approved a ₹7,300-crore Rare Earth Permanent Magnets (REPM) scheme. Under the scheme, selected manufacturers would receive capital- and sales-linked incentives to produce 6,000 tonnes a year of permanent magnets within seven years. On February 19, 2026, the Mining Minister was quoted as saying that India aims to start producing REPM by 2026-end in partnership with the private sector; the Ministry and a State-run body have developed the technology, and plans include setting up four critical mineral processing plants across as many States. In the recent Budget speech, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman proposed special Rare Earth Corridors in mineral-rich states like Odisha, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

The National Critical Mineral Mission (NCMM) is meant to push the full chain, accelerating exploration and processing, maintaining stockpiles and strengthening value chains from mining to recycling. The mission’s exploration push runs into the scale problem. Resources need to be proven into mineable reserves, and India is still early in that conversion. The Indian Bureau of Mines (IBM) has compiled data showing over 29 lakh tonnes of estimated REE resources, with Maharashtra alone at 41 per cent (over 12 lakh tonnes) and Gujarat next (11 lakh tonnes). IBM also notes India has over 58 crore tonnes of REE ore (earth/waste rock from which REEs must be extracted), but extraction at scale is yet to begin and none of it has been converted into a mining block.

Exploration and supply-side experiments are widening. These moves signal a broader push to extract value from mining wastes. On industrial side, mini-ratna company Indian Rare Earths Ltd remains the primary government-owned producer and processor of rare earth compounds. It is linked to downstream capability-building including an upcoming facility to produce samarium-cobalt magnets.

Rare earth stocks at a glance

How select REE stocks fare

Company name	Description	Currency	Adjusted TTM revenue (million)	Adjusted TTM profit (million)	M-cap (million)	EV/sales
MP Materials	Mountain Pass rare earth miner	USD	232.7	-89.1	10,379	42.4
Energy Fuels	Uranium producer building rare earth processing	USD	78.7	-93.8	5,213	63.2
Lynas Rare Earths *	Leading separated rare earth producer outside China	AUD	556.5	8.0	15,782	NA
Iluka Resources	Mineral sands major developing Eneabba rare earths refinery and downstream capacity	AUD	1,015.4	-83.3	2,363	3.4
Australian Strategic Materials	Mine-to-metals strategy; operates Korean metals plant and developing Dubbo project (to be acquired by Energy Fuels)	AUD	3.2	-24.6	425	132.6
Neo Performance Materials	Value-added rare earth materials and magnet supply chain	USD	493.4	7.3	893	1.4
China Northern Rare Earth Group	Major integrated producer	CNY	41,698.2	2,133.4	197,889	5.0
Shenghe Resources	Rare earth mining, separation, trading	CNY	13,585.7	899.1	51,638	4.1
JL MAG Rare-Earth	Neodymium-iron-boron permanent magnets maker	CNY	7,122.2	601.7	47,066	6.9

*as of CY2025 as of Feb 19, 2026 In revenue shown for some companies the REE business is still under build-out No Indian stocks in the above list Source: Bloomberg

Materials offers exposure to value-added materials that sit closer to end-use customers. Australian Strategic Materials is positioned as a mine-to-metals story with an operating metals plant footprint in Korea, while Ucore Rare Metals is effectively a technology-and-processing call where separation capability is the key variable. JL MAG is a downstream proxy.

China-listed names represent incumbency and scale. China Northern Rare Earth and Shenghe sit closer to the upstream and separation backbone, benefitting from integrated capacity and domestic demand.

Takeaway: The stocks discussed above are not recommendations. They are mere examples of the REE ecosystem and investors are expected to track their financials as the sector gains more prominence.

Assess REE stocks by where they sit in the chain (mine, separation, metals, magnets) and how proven the asset is (operating vs development).

Track execution milestones over narratives: commissioning progress, recoveries, unit costs, offtake terms, funding runway and balance-sheet resilience. Watch out for new entrants.

Nishanth Gopalakrishnan
bl. research bureau

As deals around AI and data centres continued to stack up at the AI Impact Summit, the mood elsewhere wasn't as cheerful. It's the software sector we are talking about. The rout in global software stocks has been a bottomless pit so far.

Software companies apparently face an existential threat from AI. The debate rages on whether the selloff is overdone or the disruption is serious, an outcome that no one can predict at this point in time.

Though the threat has existed for around two years now and stocks, too, have been on a slump since last year, the recent rout signals the market's acknowledgement that the threat is real. Stocks of global software bellwethers have fallen anywhere between 15 per cent and 35 per cent over the past 30 days.

Accenture and EPAM Systems are among the biggest losers with losses of 25 per cent and 35 per cent. Back home, the Nifty IT index has declined 16 per cent over the same period.

GAUGING THE CARNAGE

We use ratio charts here to better gauge the extent of this carnage. Chart 1 represents the price of iShares Expanded Tech-Software Sector ETF (IGV) to the Nasdaq Composite index's value. IGV is used as a proxy for the software sector.

Stocks of front-line software firms such as Microsoft, Palantir, Oracle, Salesforce, Palo Alto Networks, Adobe and CrowdStrike are among the top 10 holdings of the ETF today. The top 10 holdings constitute about 60 per cent of the ETF's portfolio.

The ratio chart has been re-based to 100 with the base set at the market's bottom formed in early October 2002, after the dot-com bust. A ratio of above 100 indicates the relative outperformance of the software portfolio (IGV) against Nasdaq Composite, which is also a tech-heavy index.

As can be seen from Chart 1, the ratio, which stayed above 100 for almost the entirety of the period under analysis, is now back to 100 – same level as the bottom after the dotcom bust. This implies that the entire 23 year outperformance of software stocks from the start of the great technology bull market, which started in 2002, has now been completely undone in a few months!

Further, if a drawdown chart of this ratio were to be constructed, it would reveal that the current drawdown of 37 per cent surpasses all other drawdowns over this period, including the one during 2022, when stocks reacted to interest rate tightening and firms scaling back after the Covid-



AI crushed software's 23-year outperformance

MARKET WISE. The rout in global software stocks has been a bottomless pit so far while semiconductor stocks have been on a high

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

THE BIG AI THREAT

- Global software bellwethers have fallen 15-35 per cent over the past 30 days
- Semiconductor stocks have significantly outperformed software stocks
- Valuation of some mid-cap IT stocks do not justify earnings growth

driven digitalisation boom hit some roadblocks (Chart 2). Thus, this represents the worst underperformance of software stocks relative to the Nasdaq Composite index.

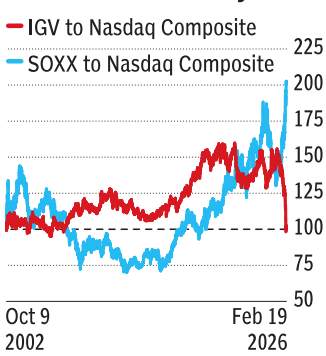
Analysing IGV's own drawdown on a standalone basis (Chart 3), the current drawdown of over 30 per cent is next only to the 50 per cent drawdown in 2009 after the sub-prime crisis and the nearly 45 per cent drawdown in 2022.

If the same ratio were to be constructed with S&P 500 as the base, the chart would look like the one in Chart 4. It can be observed that in the post-dotcom period, the ratio has been above 100 – implying the outperformance of the software portfolio relative to the broader market. However, the ratio is now at a level worse than the trough formed in 2022.

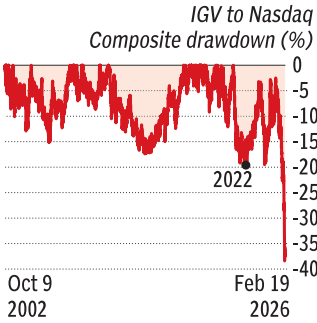
MAKING MERRY

If there is a sector that is making merry when the software stocks are trounced, it is the semiconductor sector.

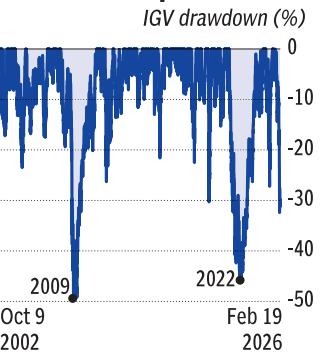
The semiconductor-software dichotomy



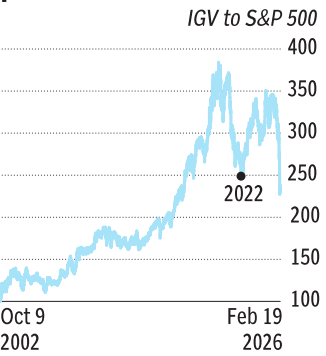
IGV to Nasdaq: Deepest drawdowns post dotcom bust



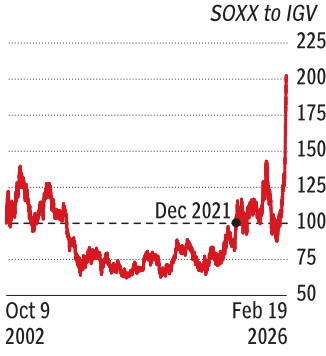
Third deepest drawdown for software post 2002



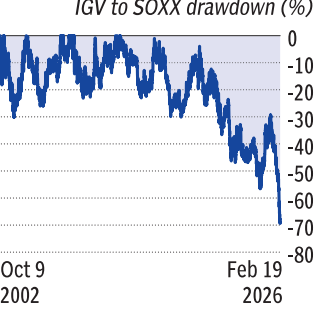
Software supremacy put to test



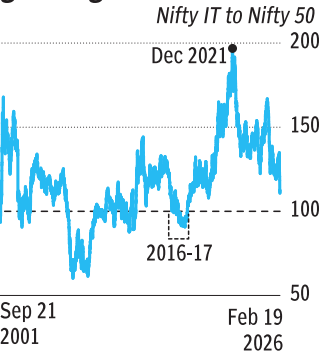
Chips make a roaring comeback



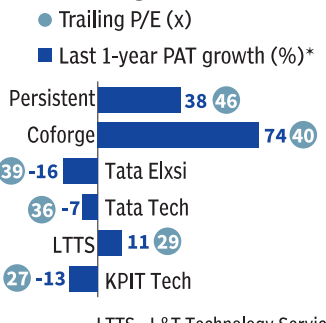
IGV to SOXX: Current drawdown trumps all drawdowns since 2002



Nifty IT's outperformance growing thin



Some Indian mid-caps are among the most expensive globally



Source: Bloomberg

*Calculated with estimated PAT for FY26 and PAT for FY25

In the ensuing AI gold rush and the arms race for chips/ GPUs, chip designers (Nvidia, for instance), memory chip companies (Micron) and semiconductor foundries/ fabs (TSMC) and suppliers of chip-making equipment (ASML, Applied Material) are

seen as the shovel sellers. The iShares Semiconductor ETF (SOXX) serves as a proxy of this sector.

The portfolio of this ETF, *inter alia*, comprises firms such as Micron Technology, Nvidia, Applied Material, TSMC, Broadcom, AMD

and ASML, which feature among the top 10 holdings today.

The top 10 holdings constitute 57 per cent of the portfolio.

A ratio chart that compares the price of SOXX with that of Nasdaq Composite is presented in Chart 1.

Unlike the software portfolio, which has almost always outperformed the Nasdaq Composite (ratio staying above 100), the semiconductor portfolio (inherently cyclical) started outperforming the index only in 2017, recovering from the troughs of

2012. The ratio is now at an all-time high in the post-dotcom period and resembles an exact mirror image of the IGV ratio chart, when seen over the last six months.

A ratio chart that studies the relative performance of SOXX against IGV is presented in Chart 5. After a long stint of relative underperformance post the sub-prime crisis till late-2021, the ratio has now skyrocketed over the last 10 months to 200. An analysis of drawdowns of the inverse of this ratio, that is, IGV to SOXX, shows how the current drawdown has snowballed over the past five-odd years to 70 per cent now – marking the worst in the post-dotcom period (Chart 6).

That said, should investors hop on to the semiconductor bandwagon? Aren't software stocks value buys now? Valuations of all major chip stocks except Nvidia and AMD are well above their five-year average multiples.

On the other hand, valuations of all software stocks are currently below their five-year averages. While under normal circumstances these are good barometers to consider, given the current exponential disruption, it is not as clear as day and night.

INDIAN CONTEXT

In the Indian context, Chart 7 studies the relative performance of Nifty IT against Nifty 50 (using the ratio of Nifty IT index value to Nifty 50 index value). Here, the base is set in September 2001, when Nifty IT bottomed after the dotcom bust. The ratio is now at 111, having fallen from the peak (about 200) of late 2021, but still above 2016-17 levels, when firms struggled in the advent of cloud/digitalisation disruption. Driven by lack of earnings growth and the advent of AI, valuations of stocks have indeed corrected, and stocks are now trading at multiples lower than five-year averages. Yet, what needs to be noted is that the stocks are still trading at valuations higher than their pre-Covid levels in December 2019 when their growth was better and there was no threat of disruption.

Hence, on that count, the valuations are still not attractive. Further, some in the mid-cap space such as Tata Elxsi, Tata Technologies, KPIT Technologies are trading at multiples that are amongst the highest in the software space globally (Chart 8). Their earnings growth rates do not justify their valuation, especially when investors globally are clueless on the extent of disruption to IT business models. While the likes of Persistent and Coforge have delivered strong growth recently, sustainability of the same remains to be seen.

The AI game is evolving day-by-day and so will the uncertainty for a while. Caution over aggression would be a better investing approach in this context.

Early retirement plan hits corpus roadblock

FINANCIAL PLANNING. How a middle-aged couple, when their dual income didn't ensure early retirement, planned for their goals

Sridevi V

Deepak and Mrinalini wanted to plan their finances. Deepak, aged 45, wanted to check if he can retire in the next five years due to health reasons. Mrinalini is career-oriented and will continue to work and is currently not looking at any specific age for retirement. Her income will likely continue till her age of 60 — for the next 18 years. They have a daughter, aged 13, and a son, aged 6.

Their goals are listed below:
* To provide ₹25 lakh for their children's education when they

turn 18 at current cost
* ₹40 lakh for daughter's marriage at her age of 25 at current cost and ₹10 lakh for son's marriage at his age of 25
* Home purchase at current cost of ₹1.4 crore before retirement
* Retirement at the earliest for a current cost of ₹75,000 per month
* School expenses of ₹4.5 lakh per year for both kids to be available for the remaining years till their son completes his schooling, if Deepak retires early
* They do not want to opt for any loan

* Both of them are comfortable with an upper middle-class lifestyle; they do not want to alter or compromise their living standards.

Both of them have considerable exposure to market-related investments and have accumulated a balanced portfolio. Deepak wants to understand if they can move to an aggressive investing style to reach his goals sooner. Both of them have adequate life cover and the family is covered for sufficient health insurance. Based on their living standards and aspirations, it was advised to update the goal cost to realistic values.

OUR RECOMMENDATION

* They have enough liquidity towards any emergency needs through their fixed income investments.

* It was suggested to allocate MF equity investments of ₹64 lakh towards children's education to fund their education at current cost of ₹40 lakh, adjusted for an inflation of 8 per cent with an expected return of 11 per cent CAGR.



GETTY IMAGES

TAKE NOTE

It is best to start planning for one's retirement as early as possible; else, the retirement age may have to be postponed

* Sukanya Samriddhi current value and MF investments of ₹23 lakh were allocated to children's marriage.

* As their high-priority goals are funded with available investments, it was suggested that they have a re-look at Deepak's early retirement and house purchase goals. It is highly unlikely that Deepak can retire at 50, as the surplus is insufficient to fund both these goals.

* Mrinalini's income after Deepak's preferred retirement age of 50 for the subsequent 13 years will help them towards family's expenses, if they can provide for own house and funds allocated towards children's school fees. This arrangement will provide cushion to the

retirement fund's growth till she retires.

* The family needs ₹4.13 crore when Deepak turns 55 with a minimal contribution equivalent to their EPF savings for the next 10 years. Hence, they can focus on their home goal with ₹1.5 lakh per month for the next five years. This will help Deepak have his own home and retire at the age of 50, with Mrinalini continuing her career till her age of 60.

* As long as Mrinalini continues working, the family expenses will be taken care of with her income. When she decides to retire, the retirement corpus — built and compounded over the years — will be readily available.

* This plan needs to be regularly reviewed to understand their change in income, behaviour and lifestyle affecting the family goals over time. There are other goals related to retirement too, like travel, children, wealth transfer, improving living standards, etc. Hence, it is essential to look at the holistic

plan before deciding on Deepak's retirement.

Retirement is a key goal for any family. Hence, it is best to start planning as early as possible; else, the retirement age

may have to be postponed.

The author is the Principal Officer at Ploutus Asset Services LLP, a SEBI registered investment advisory firm. <https://ploutus.in>

ALERTS.

One-time compensation proposed for digital fraud victims

The RBI said it will help bank customers who have faced digital fraud with a one-time compensation of up to ₹25,000 from the regulator's depositor education and awareness fund. The regulator also said it will also review and harmonise all conduct-related instructions on engagement of recovery agents and other aspects related to recovery of loans.

Cash flow

Income	Annual in ₹
Deepak salary	31,20,000
Mirunalini salary	17,40,000
Total income	48,60,000
Expenses	Annual in ₹
Living expenses	15,00,000
School fees	4,50,000
Travel	2,00,000
Rent	4,80,000
Total expenses	26,30,000
Annual surplus	22,30,000
Assets	in ₹
Fixed deposits	12,00,000
EPF Deepak	48,00,000
EPF Mirunalini	22,00,000
MF equity	1,60,00,000
NPS Deepak	8,50,000
PPF Deepak	12,50,000
NPS Mirunalini	1,25,000
PPF Mirunalini	5,25,000
SSY daughter	8,25,000
Total	2,77,75,000

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Dhuraivel Gunasekaran
bl. research bureau

For investors who seek the benefits of equity taxation without fully embracing equity market volatility, equity savings funds offer a balanced solution.

These hybrid schemes typically allocate across three avenues — equities, debt and arbitrage — with roughly 30-35 per cent in each segment.

By combining cash equity and arbitrage positions, they maintain over 65 per cent exposure to equity instruments, thereby qualifying for favourable equity taxation.

This structure makes them particularly appealing to conservative investors who aspire for returns superior to traditional fixed income, yet prefer to avoid the sharper swings associated with pure equity funds.

Mirae Asset Equity Savings Fund has now completed seven years, making it eligible for inclusion in the *bl.portfolio* Star Track MF Rating process. In the latest edition, the fund has secured a 4-star rating under the framework.

Since its launch in December 2018, the fund has delivered a compounded annualised growth rate (CAGR) of 11.3 per cent.

ASSET ALLOCATION

The fund operates with a defined structure that blends cash equities, arbitrage strategies and high-quality debt to deliver relatively stable returns with moderated downside risk.

It typically maintains net equity exposure in the 37-38 per cent range, within a historical band of 36 to 45 per cent.

Gross equity exposure is kept above 65 per cent by combining cash equity with arbitrage positions.

The arbitrage component is primarily used to bridge the gap between net equity and the 65 per cent threshold, rather than to actively chase arbitrage spreads.

Changes in net equity exposure within the permitted range are guided by a valuation framework that compares prevailing market price-to-earnings and price-to-book ratios with their long-term averages over the past 12-13 years.

Currently, the allocation stands at about 40 per cent in equity, 25 per cent in arbitrage and 35 per cent in debt.

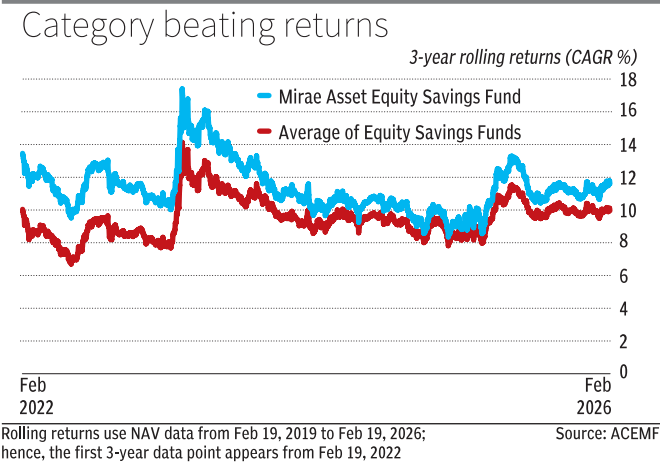
PORTFOLIO STRATEGY

Within the equity portion, stock selection is anchored in sustainable double-digit revenue growth visibility over four to five years, return on capital employed above 12-12.5 per cent post-tax, rigorous assessment of management quality and bal-



Equity, debt & arbitrage brew

FUND CALL. Mirae Asset Equity Savings Fund allocates around 40% to equities, 25% to arbitrage, and 35% to debt



ance sheet strength, and discounted cash flow-based valuation approach.

The portfolio broadly follows an 80-85 per cent growth and 15-20 per cent value orientation, with a core-plus-tactical overlay and a minimum three-year investment horizon.

Sectorally, the fund is overweight in private financials, pharma, consumption excluding staples, select auto names, cement and telecom, while remaining underweight in capital goods, infrastructure and IT services.

The constructive stance on consumption is supported by policy measures such as tax reductions and lower EMIs, which the fund manager believes are

gradually translating into improved demand conditions.

The fund maintains a clear large-cap bias, with at least 60 per cent of the equity allocation typically invested in large-cap stocks.

Currently, this proportion is closer to 72-73 per cent, reinforcing stability within the equity sleeve.

The equities deployed for arbitrage trades are entirely separate from the long (cash) equity portfolio and are not influenced by the stocks held in the core investment book.

These arbitrage positions are designed to exploit price differentials between the cash and futures markets, thereby generating relatively low-risk,



WHY INVEST

- Large-cap oriented equity portion
- High-quality debt with a low-to-moderate duration profile
- Fit for cautious investors seeking relatively lower drawdowns

market-neutral returns rather than directional equity gains.

On the debt side, the mandate focusses on G-secs and high-quality corporate bonds, with a modified duration of less than four years, emphasising capital stability over yield enhancement.

Over the past three years, the portfolio's modified duration has ranged between 1.8 and 3.5

years. As of January 2026, it stands at 2.7 years.

The latest portfolio shows around 11 per cent in AAA-rated corporate bonds, 7 per cent in papers rated AA+/AA and 10 per cent in G-secs.

Among the AA-rated exposures are names such as Piramal Finance, Muthoot Finance and Torrent Pharmaceuticals.

PERFORMANCE

The fund's performance, measured through three-year rolling returns over the past seven years, indicates that it delivered an average three-year CAGR of 11.3 per cent, outperforming the category average of 9.5 per cent.

During this period, three-year returns ranged between 8.4 per cent and 17.4 per cent, and in nearly 84 per cent of the observations, the fund delivered returns above 10 per cent.

The regular plan carries an expense ratio of 1.4 per cent, lower than the category average of 1.7 per cent, while the direct plan's expense ratio stands at 0.4 per cent, below the category average of 0.7 per cent.

The fund is suitable for cautious investors seeking relatively lower drawdowns and for those looking to park surplus funds for a two- to four-year horizon while benefiting from equity taxation.

ALERTS.

SBI MF's Nifty Midcap 150 Momentum 50 ETF

SBI MF launched SBI Nifty Midcap 150 Momentum 50 ETF, an open-ended Exchange Traded Fund replicating/tracking Nifty Midcap 150 Momentum 50 Index. The NFO closes on February 24, 2026. The entry load and exit load are not applicable for the scheme. The minimum subscription amount is ₹5,000, and in multiples of ₹1 thereafter.

ETF movers

Top ETFs (Exchange Traded Funds) traded on NSE based on weekly change in price				
	NAV (₹)	Price (₹)	Weekly change in price (%)	Volume traded in the last week (in '000s)
	as on Feb 20			
ETF				
Kotak Nifty 100 Eq Wt	34.2	38.2	12.4	355
ICICI Pru Nifty PSU Bank	97.7	97.8	5.6	1,491
Nip Ind Nifty PSU Bank	107.6	107.5	5.6	26,731
HDFC Nifty PSU Bank	97.4	97.6	5.4	225
Kotak Nifty PSU Bank	964.2	965.9	5.3	1,017
DSP Nifty PSU Bank	97.2	97.1	5.1	514
CPSE ETF	101.8	101.6	3.2	13,815
GOLD ETFs				
DSP Gold ETF	149.6	149.8	1.4	1,260
Axis Gold ETF	128.6	128.5	1.3	8,035
Zerodha Gold ETF	24.3	24.3	1.2	52,590

Source: Bloomberg. Returns as on February 20, 2026

Top PMS schemes

Based on 5-year returns						
AMC	Strategy	AUM (in ₹ cr)	Returns (% CAGR)			
			1-year	3-year	5-year	
LARGE CAP						
Tulsian PMS	Tulsian PMS	312	11.5	20.4	26.6	
ICICI Pru	Largecap	904	13.7	21.4	20.9	
Renaissance Investment	Opportunities Portfolio	NA	3.6	17.0	18.3	
Standard Chartered Securities India	SC Autograph Vibrant India Equity	NA	10.6	20.9	17.9	
MULTI CAP						
Bonanza Portfolio	Edge	NA	-4.0	20.7	27.9	
Invasset	Growth Pro Max	344	-0.4	32.6	27.6	
Asit C Mehta Invest. Intermediates	ACE - Multicap	134	7.6	30.6	27.2	
Negen Capital Services	Special Situ & Tech Fund	1,222	3.3	25.0	26.8	
Buoyant Capital	Opportunities	8,402	18.2	23.8	26.7	
Stallion Asset	Core Fund	6,361	7.2	38.5	26.6	
MID-CAP						
NAFA Asset Managers	Emerging Bluechip	NA	-0.8	18.1	20.8	
Right Horizons	Super Value	NA	-5.1	16.4	20.8	
Master Portfolio Services	Master Trust India Growth	340	4.3	16.7	20.6	
Unifi Capital	APJ 20	NA	3.8	19.2	20.3	
SMALL CAP						
Aequitas Invest. Consultancy	India Opportunities	4,862	62.3	52.5	49.2	
Counter Cyclical Investments	Diversified Long Term Value	779	-11.3	22.1	39.6	
Equitree Capital Advisors	Emerging Opportunities	1,123	-13.5	31.6	30.8	
Accuracap	Dynamo	13	0.3	28.6	25.0	

*Source: PMS Bazaar. Returns as on January 31, 2026

Aligning ETF price and trading limits with market reality

Dhuraivel Gunasekaran
bl. research bureau

Sometimes, market stress reveals gaps in trading rules. On February 1, 2026, silver ETFs slipped into sharp discounts (to their NAV) and repeatedly hit lower circuits amid heavy selling.

The episode exposed the limitations of the existing price-band mechanism at the exchanges and highlighted the need for more current reference prices and better-calibrated trading limits that reflect real-time market conditions.

Less than two weeks later, on February 13, SEBI released a consultation paper titled "Review of provisions related to Base Price and Price Bands for Exchange Traded Funds" (<https://tinyurl.com/sebietf2026>), seeking public comments on these issues. They can affect the price at which you are able to buy or sell during volatile sessions.

The consultation paper focusses on two questions: what price should exchanges use as the daily reference point, and what circuit limits should apply to ETFs?

To understand the proposals, it is important to first grasp three key concepts: NAV, iNAV and closing price.

An ETF effectively has two price references. NAV, or Net Asset Value, represents the actual value of what the ETF holds. For example, a Nifty ETF's NAV reflects the value of its underlying Nifty stocks in the same proportion.

NAV is calculated by the fund house at the end of the day and is typically published late at night, around 11 PM.

In the case of commodity ETFs with derivative exposure, NAV

may even be disclosed the following morning by 9 AM. NAV is therefore considered the fundamental value of the ETF's holdings.

iNAV, or indicative NAV, is an intraday estimate of the ETF's NAV. It is published during market hours and keeps updating based on live prices of the underlying assets. It gives investors a live estimate (not the final NAV) of the ETF's underlying value.

Closing price is the actual traded price of the ETF on the exchange.

This price is determined by demand and supply. It reflects premiums or discounts to NAV, liquidity conditions and investor sentiment. Unlike NAV, which is calculated, the closing price is discovered in the market. On exchanges, the official closing price is usually based on a weighted average of trades in the last 30 minutes.

STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINTS

Currently, exchanges determine ETF price bands using the T-2 day (two trading days earlier) closing NAV. In simple terms, if today is Wednesday, the trading limits may still be based on Monday's NAV. Exchanges also apply a fixed price band of +/-20 per cent on the base price for equity, debt, gold and silver ETFs, while Overnight ETFs investing in TREPs operate with a +/-5 per cent band.

This practice introduces a lag. Using T-2 NAV means the reference can be stale when markets move sharply. If markets move sharply on Tuesday, Wednesday's trading limits remain anchored to older data.

This can compress the effective trading range or create a disconnect between prevailing market prices and regulatory guardrails. For example, the Nippon India



REGULATORY RESET.

At the heart of SEBI's ETF consultation paper is a market structure debate over reference prices and daily limits. We analyse the pros and cons

Silver ETF's NAV was ₹359 on January 29, 2026, and that value was used as the base price for the circuit filter on February 1.

This set the allowable trading range at ₹287 to ₹431 (+/-20 per cent). In other words, the trading band was being calculated from an older, higher reference point, even though market prices had already moved lower. As selling intensified, the ETF repeatedly hit the lower circuit. The existing circuit framework left too little room for fresh price discovery, so SEBI and the exchanges allowed

an exception. They used the T-1 (previous trading day) traded price of ₹316 as the revised base price, which reset the band to ₹252.5 to ₹379. This gave the market a more workable range and allowed trading to continue. A similar pattern was seen in other silver ETFs as well.

PROPOSALS ON BASE PRICE

SEBI has proposed four possible base-price options for day T:

1. Previous day's closing traded price
2. Previous day's closing NAV

- (if available in time)
3. Average iNAV in the last 30 minutes

4. Latest available iNAV on T-1
Arun Sundaresan, Head - ETF, Nippon Life India Asset Management, prefers using the T-1 closing price over NAV. ETFs today have grown significantly in terms of AUM and trading volumes. ETFs, like stocks, undergo price discovery on exchanges. If an ETF is trading at a premium or discount, that reflects genuine demand and supply. Anchoring limits to an older NAV may fail to

● OUR TAKE

Over the long term, the T-1 closing price may offer a better anchor for trading, as it reflects the previous day's market-discovered close

capture this market dynamics, Sundaresan adds.

However, using the closing price may not be ideal for ETFs with thin trading volumes. Limited trades near market close can distort the final price and may not accurately reflect fair value.

Those who favour NAV argue that it represents the underlying fundamental value of the assets. However, the T-1 day NAV is typically published late in the night, and may not be available early enough for exchanges to set the next day's bands.

On the other hand, iNAV (either the latest number or the average of the last 30 minutes) is similar to NAV in that it reflects the indicative value of the underlying assets.

But it may not capture genuine demand and supply dynamics in the secondary market, including premiums, discounts and liquidity conditions.

Over the long term, the T-1 closing price may offer a better anchor for trading, as it reflects the previous day's market-discovered close.

REVISED CIRCUIT LIMITS

The second major proposal relates to price bands. At present, most ETFs operate with a fixed +/-20 per cent band. SEBI has proposed a tiered framework.

For equity and debt ETFs, the initial band would be +/-10 per cent. If breached, trading would

pause for 15 minutes (or 5 minutes in the last half hour). The band could then be relaxed in 5 per cent increments, up to a maximum of +/-20 per cent in a day.

For gold and silver ETFs, the initial band would be +/-6 per cent, with 15-minute cooling-off periods and subsequent relaxations in 3 per cent increments, again capped at +/-20 per cent. Overnight ETFs would continue with the existing +/-5 per cent band.

The idea is to slow sudden moves without freezing trading for the day. However, there is another view. Hemen Bhatia, ED & CEO of Angel One AMC, argues that there should be no price band for equity ETFs whose underlying indices have futures.

For instance, Nifty 50 index futures and cash market stocks do not have such bands. Similarly, gold and silver are traded globally without price limits.

If the underlying asset has no restriction, imposing limits on the ETF may not be necessary. That view supports free price discovery, but regulators may still prefer guardrails for ETFs with uneven liquidity.

TAKEAWAYS

For retail investors, these changes do not alter what your ETF owns or how it tracks its benchmark. Instead, they affect how the ETF behaves during volatile sessions.

The regulator aims to reduce distortions caused by outdated reference prices and to manage extreme movements in a more orderly manner.

Particularly for gold and silver ETFs, where global prices move overnight, the revised framework could improve alignment between domestic trading and international trends.

Wait for the green power to glow

IPO WATCH. The Clean Max offering includes a fresh issue of ₹1,200 crore and an OFS of ₹1,900 crore

Sai Prabhakar Yadavalli
bl. research bureau

Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions (Clean Max) is a leading renewable energy (RE) and services provider. As of October 2025, the company had an operational capacity of 2.8 GW (owned or managed) and another 3.17 GW capacity that is contracted and yet to be delivered.

Clean Max has reported strong revenue growth of 27 per cent CAGR in FY23-25 along with EBITDA margin expansion from 40 per cent to 60 per cent during the period. This has delivered an EBITDA growth of 55 per cent CAGR in FY23-25. But the operations are capital-intensive and despite the high EBITDA profits, the company reported profit of only ₹19 crore in FY25, as the impact of depreciation and interest are higher in the initial periods when the company is scaling up.

At the upper band of the IPO, it is valued at 17 times EV/EBITDA. While the valuation is not cheap, it is not expensive either when considering the scope for growth from contracted capacity in the next two years, robust demand from AI and data centres for RE power and relative valuation with peers.

However, execution risks and more margin of safety that is required in valuation for that, and the current context of heightened market volatility should also be considered. Given these, we recommend that investors wait and watch for now and can, therefore, skip the IPO. Given the potential, investors can keep it on their radar, track business performance post-listing and consider entering at a reasonably attractive valuation when the opportunity is presented.

The IPO values the company at ₹12,325-crore market capitalisation. It includes a fresh issue of ₹1,200 crore and an OFS of ₹1,900 crore. The fresh issue proceeds will be used to lower debt by ₹1,100 crore from a net debt of ₹8,500 crore as of September 2025. The issue is open February 23-25.

BUSINESS

Clean Max serves clients in the technology space (data centres), as also conventional clients



(GCC, FMCG, cement) through power and services sales.

As of September 2025, the company had 555 clients with an average PPA (power purchase agreement) of 22 years. With 72 per cent of FY25 revenues from repeat customers that scale up with new PPAs, the company has a strong client base.

Of the 2.8 GW operational capacity as of October 2025, 62 per cent is in solar, 11 per cent in wind and 27 per cent in hybrid (solar and wind). Business of Clean Max can be split into four segments on the basis of GW contracts (refer pie chart).

In onsite solar operations, the power plants are located within customer premises. Clean Max is responsible for setting up the facility and managing operations. In STU group captive model, the clients invest at least 26 per cent equity and purchase 51 per cent of the power generated, which allows clients to avoid additional charges on using the State grid for transmission.

In STU open access power plants of Clean Max, there is no customer equity participation and the company supplies power based on power purchase agreements. Additional charges on grid utilisation are avoided by customers under a few State government schemes (Gujarat, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka).

IPO rating

Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions	
Business	★★★★☆
Financials	★★★★☆
Management	★★★★☆
Valuation	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆
Rankings 1 to 5, 1 denoting lowest and 5 highest	
Offer period	Feb 23-25, 2026
Price band	₹1,000 - 1,053
Market cap	₹11,705-12,325 cr

STU capex refers to State Transmission Utility projects which are wholly invested in by customers and Clean Max plays the role of an EPC contractor. This business along with carbon management operations represent the services part of the company's business and accounts for 26 per cent of its revenue, while its core power business, consisting of onsite solar operations, STU group captive and STU open access, account for 74 per cent of its revenue.

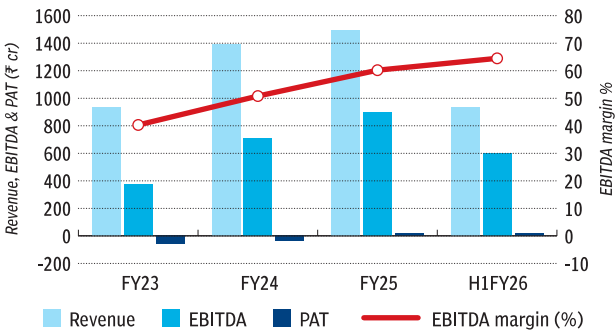
The company is also developing CTU (central transmission utility) connected projects, which can aggregate demand of the client across locations. Under this arrangement, if the client purchases from the grid, Clean Max will also sell to the grid and

How they compare

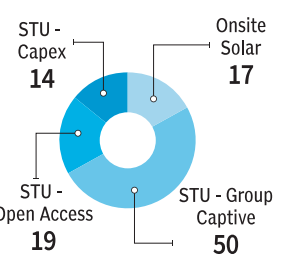
	FY25 revenue (₹ cr)	FY25 EBITDA margin (%)	FY25 Net debt to EBITDA (x)	TTM EV/EBITDA (x)*	Current P/Book (x)
Clean Max	1,496	60.2	7.1	17.3	3.6
Acme Solar	1,405	87.9	6.5	14.8	3.1
NTPC Green	2,134	89.8	8.3	48.1	4.1
Adani Green	11,212	79.3	8.4	25.3	12.6

*TTM - trailing twelve month. Clean Max EV/EBITDA is based on H1FY26 financials annualised

Improving profitability



Contracting strategy split, October 2025 (in %)



the difference in price is netted in the form of environmental attributes that are purchased by the client from Clean Max. This is a virtual PPA (VPPA) and is useful for meeting Net zero or other ESG targets of companies.

RE SUPPORT

Companies prefer RE power purchase directly from IPP (independent power producers) over the grid, as the cost is 30-40 per cent less. This aids companies to meet several ESG and Net Zero targets while saving cost.

The Indian market has aided the transition to renewable power with favourable and an evolving policy that includes an exemption from different charges or a framework that enables third-party purchases and VPPAs.

AI and data centres are the im-

mediate drivers of growth for RE demand and for the company. Clean Max will have a total capacity of about 6 GW (2.8 GW current plus 3.17 GW work in progress), of which around 2.4 GW is from the AI and data centres segment as of October 2025 compared to just 250 MW in March 2024. Growth will be driven by this segment and additional demand from GCCs, infrastructure and energy-intensive sectors that are looking to benefit from cheaper and greener power sources. With the policies in place to procure RE power as per requirement (onsite, STU, CTU or open access), the demand is expected to be strong.

The company reported 65 per cent EBITDA margin in H1FY26 compared to 80-85 per cent range for peers. As the revenue mix tilts to power generation from services, which have a 13 per cent EBITDA margin, the company should drive margin improvement as well. As with any capital-intensive industry, the depreciation and finance costs are higher during the initial years and decline in the later years. As the company expands beyond the 6-GW capacity, debt will be added. But on a larger revenue base and listed financials, the company should secure better credit rating (Care A+ currently), improving the cost of funds.

Premium residential and commercial play

REAL ESTATE. Investors with a perspective of more than three years can consider accumulating the stock of DLF

Venkatasubramanian K
bl.research bureau

As a pan-India real estate developer with an especially-strong presence in the Gurugram and Delhi markets, DLF has operations across the realty segment. A material subsidiary DCCDL (DLF Cyber City Developers Ltd) run as a JV with Singapore's GIC, runs the commercial and retail portfolios.

From residential housing to commercial areas leasing to office spaces to hospitality, the consolidated entity is a sturdy large player in the real estate segment.

In recent years, the company is also developing spaces for data centres, opening up potentially new revenue streams.

From the highs of ₹920 made in March 2024, the stock of DLF has undergone a time-wise and a price correction over the past couple of years.

At ₹629, the stock trades at 32 times its likely per share earnings for FY27.

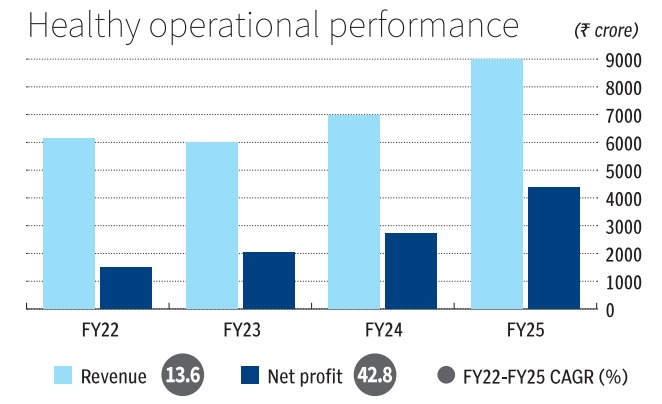
On a price-to-book basis, the multiple comes to a little over three times. Though not that inexpensive, on a relative basis compared to historical valuations, DLF provides a reasonable opportunity for long-term investors.

Over the past five years, the stock's median PE multiple has been north of 53 times. The BSE Realty index trades at a PE of almost 41 times.

The median price-to-book ratio over the past three years is around 4.4 times (Screener data).

Investors with a perspective of more than three years can consider accumulating the stock at current levels and on declines linked to the broader market.

Over the FY22-25 period, DLF's revenues grew at 13.6 per cent compounded annually to ₹8,996 crore in FY25, while net profits rose at a rate of 42.8 per



cent to ₹4,367 crore.

During 9MFY26, while total revenues rose 36.7 per cent year on year to ₹7,722 crore, net profits rose 2 per cent to ₹3,144 crore.

The relatively-mild growth in profit was due to a sharp rise in the cost of land, plots, constructed properties and development rights, and higher tax expenses. DLF's large land parcel, when it gets monetised, would result in higher profit growth over the long term though there could be lumpiness as is characteristic of the segment.

LUXURY CATEGORY

DLF has a track record of over 80 years. In addition to Gurugram and Delhi, the company has presence in Noida, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Chennai, Goa, Panchkula, Chandigarh among a few other cities.

Broadly, DLF has two businesses. The development business spans residential and commercial properties. High-rise condominiums, low-rise independent floors, plotted development and shop-cum-offices are the offerings.

The company operates only in

ACCUMULATE

DLF ₹629

WHY

- Leading player in the luxury housing segment
- Steady rise in annuity revenues
- Large land bank with lucrative development potential

the super luxury, luxury and premium segments of the market as far as the residential offerings are concerned. Considerable NRI demand exists for most of its properties.

This business accounts for about two-thirds of the consolidated revenue. There is a minor annuity business in this segment as well.

DLF's commercial arm (with 66.67 per cent stake) DCCDL is into the annuity business. This includes development and leasing of offices, renting out mall spaces, asset management and hospitality (hotels, clubs, food & beverages etc.).

This annuity business delivers steady revenue streams for the company. The business has around 49 million sq ft of rental assets. The occupancy levels are at 94 per cent, among the highest in the industry.

Over the medium term of around three years, the company hopes to generate as much as ₹10,000 crore revenue from the annuity business alone, up from ₹6,400 crore expected in FY26.

In 9MFY26, DLF launched 5.6 million sq ft of luxury segment projects worth ₹13,400 crore and 0.1 million sq ft of commercial business worth about ₹300 crore.

In the coming years, another 25-million-sq-ft worth of residential and commercial projects, valued at over ₹60,000 crore are expected, lending considerable

revenue visibility. The company has a solid land bank.

It has 14-million-sq-ft worth of projects under construction, another 13 million sq ft in the pipeline and a balance 60 million sq ft to be tapped for the future across Gurugram and a few other cities.

An Anarock report throws up an important insights.

Of the top seven cities, the National Capital Region (NCR), which includes Gurugram, saw the highest average flat size growth of 30 per cent in the last two years. The size has risen from around 1,890 sq ft in 2023 to 2,466 sq ft in 2025.

Also, the NCR region has witnessed a significant increase in new luxury supply (homes priced more than ₹1.5 crore) in this period. In 2023, the luxury homes segment accounted for a 40 per cent share of the total launches. This share has doubled to 80 per cent in 2025.

The key risk is a broader economic slowdown or heavy retrenchment in high-income segments such as IT, which could impact housing demand. This could be offset by NRIs buying high-priced homes for letting out.

HEALTHY FINANCIALS

DLF has a solid balance sheet. It has a net cash position of ₹11,660 crore, including ₹10,433 crore in RERA (real estate regulatory authority) accounts. DCCDL (a AAA-rated entity, which is higher than the parent's AA+) has a net debt of ₹16,976 crore. It is a profitable company and is witnessing rapid growth.

When we take net debt to the GAV (gross asset value) of DCCDL it is at very comfortable levels at just 0.18 times as of December 2025, down from 0.3 times in FY22. DCCDL's net debt to EBITDA was at 3 times, down from 5.5 times in FY22. The cost of debt is moderate at 7.2 per cent as of December 2025.

businessline's editorial policy prohibits analysts from taking positions in the stocks they recommend — Editor

GLOBAL BOARDROOM CHATTER.

What they say on their India plans

With India being the fastest growing large economy, 'what is your India plan?' is a common topic in boardrooms of most global corporations. One important source to distil their India plans is from their quarterly earnings calls. With the December quarter earnings season in progress, this column will present what CXOs of global corporations are saying about India, along with their perspectives and plans during the current earnings season. Here are some from companies that reported their earnings last week.

Rio Tinto Group (RIO, \$164.4 billion)

The global mining major discussed India as a potential iron ore growth opportunity over time.

"India is seeing very high growth rates in steel demand. The key question is how much iron ore demand will be met domestically versus imports. While the market structure differs from China, there will be periods of meaningful opportunity for us."

CNH Industrial N.V. (CNH, \$16.2 billion)

The agricultural equipment major emphasised India as both a manufacturing hub and a key growth market.

"We're launching new compact and utility tractors from India, with volumes building through 2026 and accelerating in 2027. We've achieved our highest-ever market share and are evaluating another site to expand capacity."

EPAM Systems, Inc. (EPAM, \$7.7 billion)

The digital engineering and IT services company emphasised India as a high-growth, high-margin region.

"India continues to grow faster than other geographies. We remain priced at a premium, and profitability is expanding beyond the company average, moving closer to our most-mature markets."

Wingstop Inc. (WING, \$7.2 billion)

The QSR chain identified India as a meaningful long-term expansion opportunity.



robust demand and portfolio expansion in India.

"The economic environment in India was very strong, and we grew our portfolio to over 12,000 wagons. Demand remained robust, supporting asset base expansion and earnings growth."

Brady Corporation (BRC, \$4.4 billion)

The identification and workplace safety solutions provider reported strong growth momentum in India.

"India led Asia with nearly 25 per cent organic sales growth this quarter. We've expanded into North and West regions, and India is now our second-largest business in Asia."

Visteon Corporation (VC, \$2.5 billion)

The automotive cockpit electronics supplier highlighted product launches and capacity expansion in India.

"In India, we launched a fully-integrated SmartCore system on Mahindra's XUV 7XO with three 12-inch displays. Capex includes building a second manufacturing facility in India to support new programs and vertical integration."

Knorr-Bremse AG (KBN, €17.9 billion)

The rail and commercial vehicle systems supplier highlighted manufacturing and digital expansion in India.

"We've entered India's first high-speed rail project, equipping two prototype trains. We're also expanding with a new AI center and a new site in Chennai that will integrate engineering and production capacity over time."

Krones AG (KRNTY, €4.3 billion)

The beverage filling and packaging equipment maker discussed early-stage operations ramp-up in India.

"Factories in China and India will start up in 2026. Revenue contribution from India will initially be small, with limited lines built locally and shipped out. The larger opportunity is in order intake, which should meaningfully contribute in 2027 and 2028."

Contributed by NFAFA ASSET MANAGERS

WHO AM I?.

Are you an avid investor? How well do you know corporate India?

Here's a challenge. Using the five clues below, identify the company that is being talked about here

- Not many listed firms can boast of a founder holding a bachelor's degree from IIT, a master's degree from Stanford, and an MBA from the Chicago Booth School.
- My founder's son, who sits on my board, graduated from Yale and began his professional career with BlackRock and McKinsey, and now actively represents a healthcare NGO.
- I have just completed my silver jubilee year, having had a humble beginning as an unorganised player, and have created a niche segment for myself in a crowded industry.
- While my founder's family continues to hold a majority stake, a financial investor who helped me scale up exited with more than a 10x return over 10 years, during which period my net profits grew at over a 30 per cent CAGR.
- I have national as well as regional icons endorsing my brand. I have a unique compensation model for my sales and marketing team that has helped me achieve the lowest employee churn in my industry.

Send your answers by Wednesday 6 p.m. to who-am-i@thehindu.co.in, with your full name, postal address and phone number. A lucky winner in each week will get a book sponsored by UNIFI Capital as a reward.

Contributed by UNIFI CAPITAL

Last week's stock: Metro Brands
Last week's winner: Kalyan Banerjee



Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Nifty 50 (25,571) and Bank Nifty (61,172) gained 0.4 per cent and 1.6 per cent respectively last week. But both indices witnessed considerable volatility over the period. Here is our analysis of futures and options data of both. As February contracts are nearing expiry, we shall consider March contracts for analysis and trade recommendations.

NIFTY 50
Nifty futures (March) (25,743), after opening with a gap-down last Monday, rebounded from the support at 25,600. But on Thursday, it fell off the resistance at 26,000. Nevertheless, it managed to close the week above the 25,500-25,600-demand zone. This support band can restrict the downside. However, for Nifty futures to establish a sustainable rally, it ought to cross over the hurdle at 26,000.

Once this happens, the contract can extend the upswing to 26,500. Although 26,250 is a minor resistance, we expect it to

be breached if the bulls get past 26,000. Supporting the bullish claim is the long build-up in March futures. As it gained 0.2 per cent last week, the outstanding open interest shot up from 16.1 lakh contracts to 56.1 lakh contracts.

Also, the Put Call Ratio (PCR) of March monthly expiry options stood at nearly 1.40 on Friday. A ratio greater than one is because of selling of relatively greater number of put options compared with call options. Traders sell puts when they hold a positive outlook.

The bullish view will be negated if Nifty futures breaches the support at 25,500. In such a scenario, the contract can quickly slip to 25,300. Support below 25,300 is at 25,000.

However, overall, Nifty futures has a support as per the chart and the derivatives data, too, shows a positive inclination. Hence, the probability for a rally is high.

Strategy: Buy Nifty futures (March) when it dips to 25,650. Place stop-loss at 25,400. When the contract rises to 26,000, tighten the stop-loss to 25,700.

Bull call spread & delivery risk

MASTERING DERIVATIVES. Option turning ITM at expiry will require taking delivery of underlying

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Delivery-based settlement changes some of the characteristics of spread strategies. This week, we discuss why you should be mindful of delivery risk in the case of bull call spread and how you can moderate the risk.

THE TRADE-OFF
We define delivery risk as the risk that the lower strike call option of your bull call spread will become in-the-money (ITM) at expiry, requiring you to take delivery of the underlying shares. This is a risk because of two reasons. One, you require large capital to buy the shares. And two, the stock price may move adversely with reference to your buying price when you sell the shares in the spot market.

The delivery risk can be moderated in two ways. One, you set up the bull call spread the typical

way and close the position just before expiry. That is, you identify an overhead resistance level for the underlying. You then buy a call option immediately above the current price (at-the-money strike) and short an out-of-the-money (OTM) call option one strike above the identified resistance level. You should close the spread position before expiry. But that would mean you will be unable to capture the maximum gains on the position. Note that the maximum gain on the spread is the difference between the strike and the net debit. This can be realised at expiry if the stock trades at or above the higher strike. Suppose you close the position at 3 pm on the expiry day. The time value of both the options will be low. So, you will be able to capture most of the gains from the position. The issue arises when the stock is trading at a price that is lower than the higher strike. Your gains

BROAD TREND

- Long build-up on index futures
- PCR of options show positive bias
- Traders can buy the dips

Book profits at 26,250.

NIFTY BANK
Nifty Bank futures (March) (61,546), like Nifty March futures, opened last week with a gap-down on Monday. Following a similar recovery to that of Nifty futures, Nifty Bank futures bounced back with the help of the support at 60,500 and rallied.

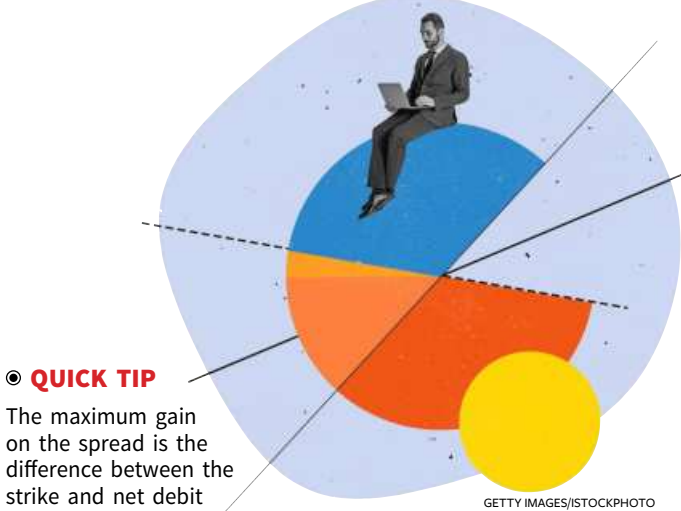
On a weekly basis, Nifty Bank futures outperformed Nifty futures. This is due to the relative performance of these contracts towards the end of the week. Nifty Bank futures posted a gain of 1.4 per cent compared to Nifty futures' 0.2 per cent.

The chart shows that Nifty Bank futures (March) has notable support levels at 61,000 and 60,500. Below these is an import-

ant base at 60,000 and only a breach of this can turn the outlook weak. As the March futures rose last week, the outstanding open interest ballooned from 1.5 lakh contracts to 8.5 lakh contracts. This denotes the arrival of fresh buyers. On the other hand, the PCR of March options stood at 1.40 on Friday. Thus, the futures and options data indicate that the bulls are in a comfortable position. Even though Nifty Bank futures might see a dip, it is likely to be stopped at 61,000 from where it can establish a fresh leg of rally.

Strategy: Buy Nifty Bank futures (March) if it moderates to 61,000. Keep stop-loss at 60,150. When the contract rises to 62,250, alter the stop-loss to 61,800. Book profits at 62,800.

Note: Recommendations are based on the chart set-up and derivatives data. Be careful about the volatility the market could witness this week due to the tariff drama. Stick to levels mentioned, especially the stop-losses. Even if you did not get entries based on our recommendations, you may stay out rather than chasing the market.



will be lower if you close the position, and the stock goes up thereafter.

An alternative strategy allows you to keep your spread position till expiry. This involves buying the same lower strike call, but the higher strike call should be below the resistance level. The objective is to have both strikes expire ITM. Why? In a delivery-based settlement, you are required to take delivery (give delivery) of the shares if you are long (short) ITM calls at expiry. When both strikes expire ITM, your broker could net-off the delivery requirement. But your gains will be lower compared to a typical call spread. This is because the gains you give-up choosing a lower

strike short leg will be more than the cost saved from a lower net debit.

OPTIONAL READING
The simplest way to avoid delivery risk is to close your call spread before expiry. You should time the action (not later than 3 pm on the expiry day) such that the realised gains are very close to the maximum gains that can be generated on the position. Note that your broker is likely to levy delivery margins on both the legs, starting four days from the expiry date.

The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments

Signs of a rally

BULLION CUES. A high-risk buying opportunity

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Gold (\$5,104/ounce) and silver (\$84.60/ounce) appreciated 1.2 per cent and 9.3 per cent respectively over the last week. In the domestic market, gold futures (₹1,56,876/10gm) rose 0.6 per cent whereas silver futures (₹2,52,944/kg) was up 3.5 per cent. Here is our analysis.

MCX-GOLD (₹1,56,876)
Gold futures (April) remained within the range of ₹1,50,000-1,61,000 over the past week. But the price action of gold in the international market gives some positive impetus and there are indications for a fresh leg of rally.

So, gold futures now stares at the prospect of breaking out of the resistance at ₹1,61,000 and rally to ₹1,70,000.

Trade strategy: Buy gold futures at ₹1,56,800 and place a stop-loss at ₹1,48,000. When the contract rises past ₹1,61,000, trail the stop-loss to ₹1,52,000. On a rally to ₹1,65,000, revise the stop-loss to ₹1,61,000. Book profits at ₹1,70,000.



MCX-SILVER (₹2,52,944)
Silver futures (March) opened last week on a weak note and slipped to a low of ₹2,26,076 on Tuesday. But it soon recovered as ₹2,80,000, trail the stop-loss to ₹2,68,000. Exit at ₹3,00,000.

While it has not breached the barriers at ₹2,68,000 and ₹2,80,000, we cannot reject the possibility of gold's positive influence on silver.

So, there is a chance for silver futures to see an uptick, possibly to ₹3,00,000.

Trade strategy: Buy silver futures at ₹2,52,900 with a stop-loss at ₹2,25,000.

When the contract touches ₹2,80,000, trail the stop-loss to ₹2,68,000. Exit at ₹3,00,000.

Risk-averse traders can avoid trades on both gold futures and silver futures.

Eyeing more gains

CRUDE CHECK. Traders can retain the longs

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

After staying flat for two weeks, oil picked up momentum last week and rallied. Brent crude oil futures on the Intercontinental Exchange (ICE) (\$71.80/barrel) was up 5.9 per cent whereas crude oil futures in the domestic market (₹6,057/barrel) gained 5.7 per cent.



BRENT FUTURES (\$71.80)
Brent crude oil futures, which consolidated between \$67 and \$69 recently, broke out of key resistances at \$69 and \$71 last week. It also surpassed the trend-line resistance at \$70. Thus, the outlook has turned bullish.

The price action in the daily chart resembles the breakout of a bull flag chart pattern and as per this set-up, Brent crude futures is likely to hit \$80 soon.

The positive outlook will change only if the price falls below the support at \$67.

MCX-CRUDE OIL (₹6,057)
Crude oil futures (March) rebounded from the support at

₹5,650 last Wednesday. It then went past the barriers at ₹5,900 and ₹6,000. This uptick shows that the contract has regained positive momentum.

While ₹6,120 is a minor resistance, we expect crude oil futures to rise above this level and touch ₹6,500 in the near term. A breakout of ₹6,500 can lift it further to ₹7,000.

But if the contract falls and breaks down below ₹5,650, the bears will gain enough traction to extend the downswing. Support below ₹5,650 is at ₹5,500.

Trade strategy: Last week, we suggested rolling over longs from February to March contract. Retain this trade initiated at about ₹5,800. Revise the stop-loss up from ₹5,450 to ₹5,650. Book profits at ₹6,500.

F & O QUERY

AKHIL NALLAMUTHU
bl. research bureau

I'm looking to buy 15000-call on Maruti. Would you suggest holding till expiry or exit at some level?

Saravanan Na

Maruti Suzuki (₹14,977): The stock saw a considerable decline through January and lost 12.6 per cent. However, it has gained 2.6 per cent so far in February. That said, the stock has not shed the bearishness fully and only a clear breakout of ₹15,500 can turn the tide in bulls' favour.

So, as it stands, the likelihood of resumption in decline is high. So, we would suggest avoiding call options at the current levels. Once the stock surpasses the resistance at ₹15,500, you can go long on calls. If such a move occurs before the end of February, we would still suggest you consider March contracts so that you can avoid fighting time decay.

What is the outlook for Voltas? Can I consider trading options on the stock?

Tarun Dutta

Voltas (₹1,546.90): The stock has now posted gains for three consecutive weeks. But the gains have been shrinking and last week it was up by 1.4 per cent. But this is not something bearish because, the recent rally has lifted the stock above key resistance at ₹1,470. Moreover, it has been able to sustain above this level.

That said, the scrip is now hovering near another barrier at ₹1,550. So, from the current level, the stock might see a dip, possibly to ₹1,500, before it breaks out of ₹1,550. Overall, with or without a corrective decline, we expect the stock to eventually surpass ₹1,550 and rise to ₹1,640. A breakout of this can take it higher to ₹1,800. Given the aforementioned factors, you can consider buying call options (we recommend opting for March contracts instead of February contracts to avoid time decay). But rather than buying now, you can purchase options if the stock price dips to ₹1,500 or after the breakout of the hurdle at ₹1,550, whichever happens first.

Send your queries to derivatives@thehindu.co.in.

Scrip	FII		Retail	
	As on Feb 20	Weekly change %	As on Feb 20	Weekly change %
Future Index Long	68265	46	151247	-1
Future Index Short	201929	4	75354	7
Net Futures	-133664	-9	75893	-9
Index Call options Long	752420	-12	2911784	-22
Index Call options Short	691865	-16	3148473	-15
Net Call options	60555	119	-236689	-2325
Index Put options Long	979273	3	2504251	23
Index Put options Short	674386	16	2933036	13
Net Put Options	304887	-18	-428785	-23

FIs have slightly reduced net short in index futures. But they have more than doubled net long in index calls and cut net long in index puts. No clear indication.

Company	Price (₹)	Weekly price change %	OI (in lakh)	Weekly OI change %
RISE (as on Feb 20)				
ABB	5,987.00	3.6	76.8	67.4
PERSISTENT	5,092.00	-7.1	93.6	48.2
ONGC	278.65	4.2	3432.0	32.8
ANGELONE	2,496.30	-7.5	84.4	25.3
CUMMINSIND	4,733.90	7.3	68.1	24.7
FALL (as on Feb 20)				
IRCTC	645.30	4.5	240.9	-45.4
KFINTECH	1,007.40	4.1	74.0	-26.8
RVNL	312.10	1.0	1370.2	-21.3
CANBK	154.15	8.7	3766.1	-20.6
BDL	1,310.40	5.4	183.9	-20.5

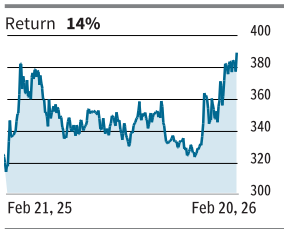
SAIL	SAMMAANCAP
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Symbol	Expiry date (2026)	Price (₹)	OI	Indication
COMMODITIES (as on Feb 20)				
ALUMINIUM	31-Mar	311.3 (-0.4)	3,026 (106)	Short build-up
COPPER	31-Mar	1,196.1 (-3.2)	11,650 (55)	Short build-up
CRUDEOIL	19-Mar	6,057.0 (5.7)	14,582 (80)	Long build-up
CRUDEOILM	19-Mar	6,054.0 (5.6)	9,886 (4)	Long build-up
GOLD	2-Apr	156,876.0 (0.6)	7,534 (-2)	Short covering
GOLDGUINEA	31-Mar	128,839.0 (0.0)	11,769 (24)	Short build-up
GOLDM	3-Apr	156,964.0 (0.7)	16,370 (34)	Long build-up
GOLDPETAL	31-Mar	16,152.0 (0.0)	152,375 (37)	Short build-up
GOLDTEN	31-Mar	158,207.0 (-0.3)	20,306 (35)	Short build-up
LEAD	31-Mar	188.8 (-0.2)	319 (37)	Short build-up
NATURALGAS	26-Mar	277.2 (-1.4)	9,740 (98)	Short build-up
SILVER	5-Mar	252,944.0 (3.5)	5,894 (1)	Long build-up
SILVERM	30-Apr	263,346.0 (2.6)	9,799 (65)	Long build-up
SILVERMIC	30-Apr	263,413.0 (2.5)	33,166 (51)	Long build-up
ZINC	31-Mar	326.1 (-0.3)	3,543 (24)	Short build-up
CURRENCIES (as on Feb 20)				
USDINR	25-Mar	91.12 (0.2)	282812 (203)	Long build-up
EURINR	25-Mar	107.4 (-)	309 (-)	-
GBPINR	25-Mar	123.22 (-)	16 (-)	-

F&O Strategy Buy NTPC March call

KS Badri Narayanan

After a strong rally in recent times, the outlook turned positive for NTPC (₹372.95). A close above the resistance at ₹395 can trigger fresh rally that can take the price to new peaks. Nearest support levels are at ₹358 and ₹342.



F&O pointers: NTPC Feb futures (expiring on Tuesday) and Mar futures closed at ₹371.70 and ₹374.15 respectively against the spot price of ₹372.95. Open interest saw a steady build up along with a rise in share price. Rollover to March contract stood at a healthy 55 per cent.

Strategy: Consider buying 372.50-call of March expiry that closed with a premium of ₹11 on Friday. As the market lot is 1,500 shares, this strategy would cost ₹16,500. Initial stop-loss can be ₹6.5. Shift it to ₹10, if NTPC opens on a positive note on Monday. Target can be ₹18.

If NTPC opens above ₹378 or below ₹362 on Monday, traders can avoid this trade. Market will remain volatile and so, this strategy suits participants who understand the risk involved in buying options.

Follow-up: Though the stock of TVS Motor displayed some resilience on the first three days of last week and provided some profit opportunities, Thursday's sharp fall would have triggered stop-loss.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis and F&O positions. There is a risk of loss in trading

Short Take Angel One F&O adjustments

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Angel One (₹2,496.30), on February 19, announced a share split. The record date for the same is February 26 and the ratio is 10:1. The split will lead to necessary adjustments in the futures and options (F&O) contracts. The adjustment factor will be 10.

On February 26, the stock price and all derivatives contracts on Angel One will be adjusted appropriately.



With respect to futures contracts, the reference rate of the relevant contract on February 25 will be considered. Reference rate will be the mark-to-market settlement price of the relevant futures contract. So, the open positions shall be carried forward to February 26 at the daily settlement price on February 25 divided by 10, the adjustment factor.

Suppose the nearest expiry futures closes at ₹2,500 on February 25, it will be revised to ₹250 (₹2,500 divided by 10). Also, the lot size will be increased 10 times from current 250 shares to 2,500 shares per contract.

For options, all the strike prices in the option chain of Angel One will be divided by 10 from February 26. For example, the strike price of 2,500 and 2,600 will be modified to 250 and 260 respectively.

That said, the aforementioned measures are not likely to impact the overall trend of this stock. So, traders can stick to their views and are only required to note the changes.

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Nifty 50, Sensex and the Nifty Bank index began the week on a positive note and moved up well in the first half. But then the indices reversed sharply lower in the second half of the week giving away most of the gains.

The US Supreme Court striking down the tariffs levied by the President Donald Trump is a positive factor for the market. However, uncertainty still prevails as all eyes are on Trump to see what will be next? So, we will have to wait and watch how the market reacts to this news on Monday.

That said, on the charts nothing much has changed. There are no major warning signals. The bias continues to remain positive. Supports are there to limit the downside.

FPIs SELL

The Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have turned net sellers of Indian equities again after buying for two consecutive weeks. The equity segment saw a net outflow of about \$304 million last week.

NIFTY 50 (25,571.25)

Short-term view: The struggle to breach the psychological 26,000 mark continues. However, support is in the 25,200-25,100 region. We expect the Nifty to sustain above this support and rise back to 26,000. Eventually we expect the Nifty to break 26,000 and rise to 26,400-26,500 in the short term.

In case the index breaks below 25,100, an extended fall to 24,800 or 24,400 can be seen. In that scenario, the rise to 26,000 and higher levels will happen with a delay.

Medium-term view: The broader bullish view will remain intact as long as the index stays above the 24,000-23,500 support zone. We retain our view of the Nifty rising to 27,500-28,000 in the medium term and 30,000-31,000 in the long term. A decisive break above 26,500 can trigger this rally.

Nifty has to fall below 24,000 to come under pressure. A subsequent break below 23,500 will only negate our bullish view.

NIFTY BANK (61,172)

Short-term view: The support at 59,750 mentioned last week has held very well. Sup-

Hanging in there

INDEX OUTLOOK. Downside could be limited as good supports are ready to cushion the fall

Nifty 50: Limited room to fall



NEAR-TERM SUPPORTS

- Nifty 50: 25,200, 25,100
- Sensex: 82,150, 82,000
- Nifty Bank: 60,100, 59,600

upside remains open for the Sensex to see 89,000-90,000 in the medium term and 98,000-99,000 in the long term.

Sensex has to fall below 79,500 to negate the bullish view.

NIFTY MIDCAP 150 (21,918.20)

The resistance around 22,200 is continuing to cap the upside. Support is in the 21,600-21,500 region. We expect the index to hold above this support and breach 22,200 eventually. Such a break can take the Nifty Midcap 150 index up to 22,800 initially.

A break above 22,800 will boost the momentum. Such a break can take the Nifty Midcap 150 index up to 26,000-26,500 in the medium term and 28,000-28,500 in the long term.

The short-term picture will turn negative if the index declines below 21,500. In that case, a fall to 21,000-20,700 can be seen. The region around 20,000 is a crucial long-term support.

The outlook will turn bearish

only if the index declines below this support.

NIFTY SMALLCAP 250 (15,958.80)

The index is struggling to get a strong follow-through rise over the last two weeks. A decisive break above 16,200 is needed to go up towards 16,500-16,600.

Immediate support is at 15,800. A break below it can drag the index down to 15,300-15,200 in the short term.

The long-term picture looks bullish with a strong support around 15,000. We expect the Nifty Smallcap 250 index to see a rally to 22,500-23,000. A break above 18,300, an important resistance, can clear the way for this rally. As such, this could be a good time to enter the Smallcap segment.

A fall below 15,000 is needed to negate this bullish view.



Watch **bl. Guru** share the Nifty and Bank Nifty technical outlook for this week

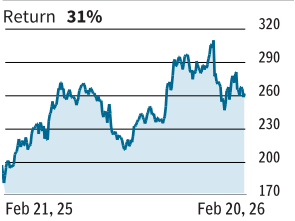


MOVERS & SHAKERS

AKHIL NALLAMUTHU bl. research bureau

BHEL (₹257.15)

Support ahead



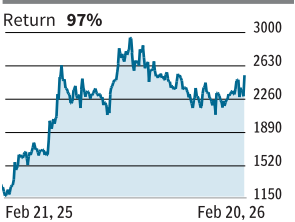
The stock of BHEL (Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd) has been appreciating since March last year. It has been forming higher highs and higher lows since then.

While it has seen a decline in price so far this year, it remains above key support at ₹240, where a rising

trendline coincides. So, we expect the stock to resume the rally either from the current level or after a dip to ₹240. Once the upswing begins, the stock can reach ₹350 over the medium term. Buy the stock at ₹257 and ₹240. Place stop-loss at ₹225. When the stock rises to ₹300 and ₹325, trail the stop-loss to ₹275 and ₹300 respectively. Book profits at ₹350.

Centum Electronics (₹2,537.20)

Rebounds from a base

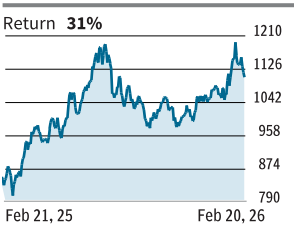


The stock of Centum Electronics, which was in a downtrend between September and December last year, was consolidating in January. Towards the end of last month, it started showing signs of bullish momentum picking up and the price inched up. Last

Friday, it rallied over 10 per cent, indicating that the bulls are gaining traction. Also, the scrip has made higher high and the 21- and 50-day moving averages has seen a bullish crossover. So, the likelihood of a rally is high. Traders can go long at ₹2,537 and accumulate at ₹2,380. Place stop-loss at ₹2,200 first and revise it to ₹2,750 when the price hits ₹3,000. Exit at ₹3,200.

The Ramco Cements (₹1,112.35)

Set to resume the rally



The Ramco Cements stock has been in an uptrend since November last year. It established a rally on the back of the support at ₹970 and confirmed a double-bottom chart pattern by mid-January, turning the trend bullish. After hitting a record high of

₹1,214 before a couple of weeks, the price moderated. Nevertheless, the uptrend remains intact. So, we expect the stock to begin rising either from the current level or after a dip to ₹1,090. Therefore, participants can buy the stock now at ₹1,112 and buy more shares at ₹1,090. Stop-loss can be ₹1,060. Revise the stop-loss to ₹1,180, when the price hits ₹1,230. Exit at ₹1,300.

Signs of a trend reversal

Gurumurthy K

bl. research bureau

Dow Jones, S&P 500 and the Nasdaq Composite indices recovered last week and closed in green. The Dow Jones seems to be struggling to get a strong follow-through rise after making a bullish breakout a couple of weeks ago. The S&P 500 seems to be turning down gradually. The price action in the coming weeks will need a very close watch. The NASDAQ Composite looks much weaker among the lot.

The US Supreme Court striking down the tariffs levied by the President Donald Trump has given a push for the equities on Friday. We will have to wait and see if this can sustain or not.

DOW JONES (49,625.97)

Support is in the 49,200-49,000 region. The Dow has to sustain above this support in order to go up towards 50,700-50,800 in the short term.

In case the index breaks below 49,000 from here, a fall to 48,000 is possible.

Broadly, 48,000-51,000 can be the wide trading range. A break below 48,000 will turn the outlook bearish for a fall to 45,000.

On the other hand, a decisive break above 51,000 is needed to clear the way for a rise to 55,000 and higher.

Considering the lack of strength in S&P 500 and NASDAQ Composite, we prefer to remain cautious on the Dow Jones rather than being bullish. So, it is better to look at the market from the sell side rather than making fresh buys at the moment.

S&P 500 (6,909.51)

The index has been broadly range-bound between 6,700 and 7,000 since December last year. However, a close look at the price action on the charts indicate that the index is gradually turning down.

A fall below 6,770 could be an initial bearish signal. A subsequent break below 6,700 will confirm the bearish trend reversal. It will then increase the danger of seeing 6,600-6,500 and even lower levels going forward.

A break above 7,000 and a subsequent rise past 7,100 is needed to negate the aforementioned fall. Only then the upside will open up for a fresh rise to 7,400-7,500.

NASDAQ COMPOSITE (22,886.07)

The bounce last week has given some relief for the NASDAQ Composite index. However, the view remains negative.

The region between 23,000 and 23,300 will be a strong resistance zone which can cap the upside. NASDAQ Composite index can fall to 21,900 or even 21,600 from here.

A strong break above 23,300 is needed to avoid this fall and take the index higher to 24,000.

Ideally, the index has to get a decisive break above 24,000 to bring back the bullishness. Only then a fresh rally to 26,000 and higher is possible.

But on the charts, a fall to 21,600 first looks more imminent from here.



US MARKET OUTLOOK.

Charts indicate absence of fresh buyers

RANGE-BOUND

The dollar index is stuck between 96.50 and 98.10 over the last few weeks

DOLLAR INDEX OUTLOOK

The dollar index (97.79) has been hovering around 97 since the beginning of this month. The trading range so far this month has been 96.50-98.10. A breakout on either side this range will determine the next move.

A break above 98.10 can take the index higher to 99.50. On the other hand, a fall below 96.50 can drag it down to 95. We will have to wait and see.

TREASURY YIELD

The US 10Yr Treasury Yield (4.09 per cent) is managing to hold well above 4 per cent. Cluster of supports are there in the 4-3.9 per cent region. So, the downside could be limited even if the yield falls below 4 per cent from here. Immediate resistance is around 4.13 per cent. A break above it can take the US 10Yr Yield higher to 4.2-4.25 per cent.

From a long-term perspective, as long as the yield sustains above 3.9 per cent, the bias will remain bullish to breach the 4.3-4.35 resistance zone. Such a break can take the US 10Yr Yield up to 4.5-4.6 in the coming months.

Valuation Radar: The Good, The Bad, The Ugly

The Benchmark indices, Sensex and Nifty 50, were up 0.2 per cent and 0.4 per cent, respectively last week. BSE Power and BSE PSU were the top movers, delivering 2.5 per cent and 2.2 per cent, respectively. BSE IT and BSE Teck declined the most by 1.7 and 1.5 per cent, respectively last week

The sector indices are disseminated by S&P BSE.

Company	CMP	EPS	PE	PB	Year End	Sales Qty	Profit Qty	Sales TTM	Profit TTM	Wkly Rtn	ROCE	DER	Yr.High	Yr.Low
360 One [1]	3099.8	29.0	37.9	4.8	202512	51.5	18.4	22.1	30.0	-2.3	14.3	0.0	1273.0	766.1
3M India [1]	10150.9	542.7	66.6	19.0	202512	0.5	21.6	20.1	20.3	2.6	39.8	0.0	3830.0	2551.4
A B B [2]	5985.4	78.8	76.0	48.8	202512	5.1	-18.3	27.4	39.4	3.3	9.8	0.1	6299.8	4590.1
A B Real Estate [2]	1299.4	-19.0	3.8	202512	-59.8	-389.2	-52.3	-317.9	-6.4	-0.2	1.0	2.535.0	1185.1	
Aadhar Hsg. Fin.	479.4	24.0	20.0	3.0	202512	18.8	20.7	18.7	20.0	2.8	11.4	2.8	547.8	340.5
Adani Industries [5]	4511.1	10.2	44.1	2.9	202512	25.8	221.7	13.3	1.6	1.1	6.2	0.7	494.0	338.2
Adani Ports [2]	1511.5	54.8	20.7	0.4	202512	12.1	24.9	26.3	18.9	-0.5	12.2	0.2	2358.4	126.4
Abbott India [2]	26263.4	71.3	66.6	13.9	202512	6.8	4.2	9.3	14.2	-0.8	45.0	0.0	5992.9	6260.6
ACC	1613.3	14.0	12.0	1.5	202512	8.6	-65.4	16.4	4.7	-1.5	17.9	0.0	2123.3	1594.5
ACME Solar Hold. [2]	231.6	8.3	28.0	2.9	202512	42.3	-3.7	61.7	319.0	3.1	7.4	2.8	324.3	172.9
Action Const.Ec. [2]	864.9	35.5	24.4	5.8	202512	12.2	29.7	10.8	21.0	8.6	-3.6	0.0	1390.0	75.0
Adani Energy Sol.	997.6	18.7	33.4	5.1	202512	15.4	-1.7	20.0	4.8	1.0	10.1	0.2	1067.3	639.4
Adani Enterp. [1]	2160.5	28.7	75.2	4.6	202512	8.6	1823.5	-5.1	-15.4	0.9	9.0	1.8	2612.8	1850.0
Adani Green	967.4	10.4	93.5	8.2	202512	7.6	-106.8	14.8	10.1	1.8	9.4	6.4	1179.2	758.0
Adani Ports [2]	1511.5	54.8	27.6	4.1	202512	21.9	24.9	26.3	18.9	-0.5	12.2	0.2	2358.4	126.4
Adani Power [2]	142.7	5.9	24.0	2.5	202512	18.9	14.9	18.9	12.2	-0.0	11.2	0.7	182.8	92.3
Adani Total Gas [1]	519.4	5.8	89.0	12.7	202512	16.4	11.4	17.7	-3.9	-0.1	17.4	0.0	79.4	57.0
Aditya AMC [5]	918.3	35.3	26.0	7.4	202512	7.4	21.0	12.0	11.8	5.7	35.5	0.0	921.0	562.5
Aditya Bkr. Fas.	69.8	6.2	1.4	202512	0.9	-215.9	8.7	4.5	-5.7	0.0	1.3	1.7	7.0	45.0
Aditya Birla Cap. [2]	345.1	11.4	25.5	2.4	202512	27.4	40.2	13.8	29.4	4.7	4.5	369.3	150.0	95.2
Aegis Logistics [1]	698.6	21.6	31.6	4.1	202512	1.1	42.3	7.9	33.1	-1.0	14.5	0.9	946.5	639.5
Aether Industries [1]	967.1	16.9	57.4	5.5	202512	44.4	46.2	52.7	93.2	0.0	9.7	0.1	1085.5	723.2
Affcon Infrastr.	520.2	13.9	23.0	2.2	202512	-7.3	5.7	-3.1	-1.9	-3.6	14.4	0.6	498.9	315.3
Aflac India [2]	1488.8	21.1	17.8	1.8	202512	17.2	42.9	36.2	27.2	-1.7	25.6	0.1	2188.8	132.4
AIA Engineering [2]	3946.2	124.8	31.6	5.0	202512	-0.1	14.6	-2.6	10.3	-0.2	19.1	0.1	4200.0	3000.6
Ajanta Pharma [2]	2936.8	81.2	36.2	8.5	202512	20.0	17.6	14.8	13.0	0.6	32.0	0.0	2025.0	216.1
Akzo Nobel	3602.0	85.9	6.9	6.2	202512	-13.6	12.5	-7.0	12.1	3.7	39.1	0.1	3909.3	2649.1
Alkermida Pharma [2]	3017.2	44.1	68.4	3.1	202512	10.8	29.7	10.8	29.7	14.2	12.1	0.1	1101.8	994.0
Alkem Lab [2]	5392.6	200.9	26.8	4.8	202512	10.7	8.2	11.7	11.0	-0.2	20.0	0.0	5913.0	4498.9
Alkyl Amines [2]	1517.1	35.3	42.9	5.4	202512	-4.6	-3.4	-0.5	1.2	-0.2	18.2	0.0	2448.8	1505.0
Allied Blenders [2]	501.2	9.6	52.3	9.0	202512	3.0	19.5	14.0	135.6	-5.3	21.0	0.9	720.0	278.9
Alkermida Pharma [2]	3017.2	44.1	68.4	3.1	202512	10.8	29.7	10.8	29.7	14.2	12.1	0.1	1101.8	994.0
Amara Raja Ener. [1]	855.5	37.4	22.8	2.0	202512	4.2	-22.2	5.1	-26.8	1.6	15.6	0.0	1086.7	805.1
Amber Enterp.	7649.0	66.1	115.7	7.4	202512	37.9	26.4	30.7	4.6	-1.0	13.5	0.8	8125.0	5404.4
Ambuja Cements [2]	512.1	15.7	32.7	2.3	202512	9.2	89.9	16.4	-8.7	-1.4	12.7	0.0	625.0	455.0
Ambuja Pathi Wa. [2]	3017.2	44.1	68.4	3.1	202512	10.8	29.7	10.8	29.7	14.2	12.1	0.1	1101.8	994.0
Anant Raj [2]	548.8	14.6	37.5	3.6	202512	20.0	30.8	22.6	36.8	-2.9	10.9	0.1	744.1	366.2
Angel One	2497.9	84.6	29.5	3.9	202512	5.8	-4.6	-14.6	-42.5	0.7	25.8	0.7	3283.0	1427.0
Apas Indrs.	10512.6	246.9	42.6	8.7	202512	16.3	29.8	20.8	22.8	10.7	32.6	0.1	10774.1	4920.0
Apollon Tubes [2]	1117.2	46.2	19.8	1.8	202512	17.6	42.9	36.2	27.2	-1.7	25.6	0.1	2188.8	132.4
Apollo Hospitals [5]	611.1	126.3	60.2	12.8	202512	17.2	38.8	14.5	38.6	1.0	17.5	0.6	8099.0	602.0
Apollo Tyres [1]	455.2	23.0	19.8	1.9	202512	11.8	43.4	6.2	8.3	-7.0	10.9	0.3	540.0	368.0
Apus Value Hou. [2]	242.1	17.8	13.6	2.6	202512	23.0	24.0	28.1	25.5	-2.6	15.1	0.5	364.9	241.4
Aptiv India Gas [2]	947.6	12.3	77.0	6.5	202512	40.4	32.8	8.0	31.8	-1.7	13.1	0.9	1073.0	576.6
Ashok Leyland [1]	308.8	13.4	25.5	2.8	202512	23.6	13.4	30.1	30.8	-0.3	14.5	0.3	215.4	95.2
Asian Paints [1]	2428.4	42.6	57.0	11.9	202512	3.9	5.7	1.3	-6.4	-2.7	24.4	0.1	2985.5	2125.0
Aster DM Health.	631.0	7.0	90.0	7.8	202512	12.9	10.1	8.5	38.5	5.2	11.6	0.5	73.0	326.2
Astral [1]	1167.2	46.2	19.8	1.8	202512	17.6	42.9	36.2	27.2	-1.7	25.6	0.1	2188.8	132.4
Astramarec Phar [2]	8902.9	83.2	107.0	12.9	202512	38.9	-42.3	34.5	24.1	0.3	32.9	0.0	10550.1	6501.6
Ather Energy [1]	708.9	-16.9	10.0	10.2	202512	5.0	-140.2	50.9	25.0	0.1	1.1	0.0	790.0	287.3
Atul	6583.6	101.8	32.6	3.3	202512	11.1	47.8	13.3	42.9	-0.5	12.8	0.0	7193.0	4882.0
AU Small Finance	2020.9	30.9	33.3	4.2	202512	14.9	26.3	22.3	13.6	3.4	0.0	0.0	1038.8	479.0
Aurobindo Pharma [1]	1181.8	60.9	19.4	6.8	202512	12.8	9.0	-22.4	4.0	-2.4	14.6	0.9	1376.6	810.0
Avenue Invest [1]	505.9	42.8	11.8	2.6	202512	-22.5	-70.2	-16.0	-9.5	-4.1	29.7	0.1	683.5	266.6
Avenue Super.	3859.4	40.4	87.7	11.0	202512	13.3	18.3	15.4	5.3	-1.2	18.0	0.0	4916.3	3337.1
AVL Agra Busine. [1]	198.4	7.4	26.9	2.6	202512	10.5	-30.0	21.8	-19.5	-1.6	19.8	0.3	291.3	195.0
Axis Bank [2]	1368.3	84.5	16.2	2.1	202512	4.8	4.0	4.5	-6.8	2.6	0.0	0.0	1413.3	992.0

BHEL [2]	257.2	2.3	110.0	3.7	202512	16.4	189.8	10.4	56.9	0.6	3.2	0.4	305.9	176.0
B K PCL [2]	365.9	57.6	30.7	1.7	202512	5.2	90.0	0.5	78.3	-2.3	-15.7	0.7	391.9	234.2
Bajaj Auto	9806.9	319.9	30.7	8.0	202512	21.2	27.8	14.8	18.7	0.5	28.1	0.2	10059.1	7088.3
Bajaj Finance [1]	102.29	29.3	35.2	6.2	202512	18.4	-2.1	20.7	14.0	0.5	11.4	0.3	110.5	81.4
Bajaj Finserv [1]	2058.0	62.1	33.1	4.3	202512	24.9	11.6	15.6	15.9	1.7	12.4	4.9	2194.7	1733.2
Bajaj Holdings	1117.2	66.0	16.9	1.8	202512	127.6	15.3	-34.1	-2.2	2.7	11.5	0.0	104873.2	10406.0
Bajaj Housing	88.1	3.0	29.5	3.5	202512	18.2	23.2	18.9	27.1	-1.4	9.5	4.7	137.0	87.2
Balkrishna Inds [2]	2496.4	67.9	36.8	4.6	202512	6.9	-15.0	2.6	-26.0	-4.5	17.9	0.3	2815.4	2157.4
Balarampur Chini [1]	456.3	22.2	20.6	2.4	202512	22.0	61.0	15.4	9.0	-1.9	11.1	0.6	62.0	39.3
Bandhan Bank	371.3	6.3	27.4	1.1	202512	-0.9	51.8	0.0	59.4	3.5	0.0	0.0	192.5	132.2
Bank of Baroda [2]	109.0	37.6	8.2	1.0	202512	3.2	4.4	4.7	4.7	7.5	0.0	0.0	313.3	190.7
Bank of India	171.8	22.4	7.7	1.0	202512	4.0	6.7	7.9	19.7	6.1	0.0	0.0	17.4	9.2
Bank of Maha	68.8	8.4	8.2	1.7	202512	16.1	27.4	19.3	22.9	5.2	0.0	0.0	69.9	38.1
BASF India	3572.3	43.3	42.4	4.1	202512	6.3	0.9	-19.9	-39.7	-2.2	17.9	0.1	5418.2	352.9
Bata India [2]	812.0	14.4	54.4	6.8	202512	2.8	9.0	-0.6	-23.4	-5.0	14.6	0.9	1376.6	810.0
Bayer Crop Sci.	4800.0	149.2	32.2	6.9	202512	4.6	179.8	7.7	28.7	0.4	23.8	0.0	4800.0	4276.9
BEML Ltd. [1]	1706.3	29.9	57.1	5.1	202512	23.7	-191.7	84.4	-0.8	-1.8	11.7	0.1	2437.4	1173.2
Berger Paints [1]	455.0	8.6	47.3	8.5	202512	0.3	5.1	5.1	-1.7	-1.5	24.8	0.1	604.6	449.0
Bharat Dynamics [5]	1130.7	15.8	82.8	11.4	202512	-31.4	50.4	57.2	2.5	5.3	10.2	0.0	2096.0	988.9
Bharat Electron [1]	441.2	8.2	54.1	15.0	202512	24.0	20.5	14.5	19.5	1.3	36.9	0.0	461.4	243.5
Bharat Forge [2]	1780.4	24.4	72.8	9.1	202512	25.0	41.3	4.5	18.2	-2.4	11.7	0.9	1801.0	91.4
Bharti Airtel [5]	1997.7	53.8	36.7	9.6	202512	15.6	-12.1	25.0	58.0	-1.3	14.3	2.2	2174.7	1561.0
Bharti Hexacom [5]	168.1	35.2	47.9	13.5	202512	4.8	48.7	13.6	63.9	0.9	16.5	1.5	2051.0	1225.0
Bikaji Foods [1]	634.9	10.0	63.7	10.6	202512	11.2	117.6	13.9	-8.3	-0.7	18.4	0.2	820.9	601.8
Biocon [5]	384.0	5.1	76.0	1.6	202512	9.3	1733.6	14.4	5.9	1.6	6.9	0.8	425.0	290.8
Birla Corp.	1013.0	74.2	13.7	1.3	202512	-4.3	141.6	6.4	151.7	-3.6	7.2	0.6	1537.2	90.8
Birlasoft Ltd [2]	378.7	17.5	21.7	2.9	202512	-1.1	22.7	-2.6	-15.1	-5.0	20.8	0.0	484.6	330.9
BLU Internet [1]	288.6	15.6	17.2	5.2	202512	39.6	34.8	4.7	41.9	-0.4	39.0	0.1	428.3	246.1
Blue Bird Express [5]	465.5	50.7	45.5	40.7	202512	1.0	50.7	1.0	50.7	1.0	50.7	1.0	50.7	1.0
Blue Jet Health [2]	35.5	16.9	21.0	4.9	202512	-39.6	59.4	20.6	25.1	-10.6	4.0	0.0	1028.2	352.8
Blue Star [2]	1968.3	26.0	75.7	13.0	202512	4.2	-2.0	9.5	-2.6	-1.4	25.8	0.1	2266.7	1521.2
Bosch	35214.3	783.8	44.9	7.4	202512	9.4	7.9	11.3	14.2	-1.4	20.5	0.4	44984.25938.2	347.0
Bosch Power Solutions	12.4	12.4	12.4	12.4	202512	-77.2	-12.4	-77.2	-12.4	-77.2	-12.4	-77.2	-12.4	-77.2
Brigade Enterprise [2]	740.4	3.1	23.8	2.8	202512	7.6	-15.1	7.2	17.8	-3.0	13.3	1.2	1332.4	710.8
Britannia Inds [1]	6095.0	100.3	60.8	39.3	202512	9.5	16.9	8.0	11.0	1.9	51.9	0.4	6337.0	4506.5

What new income tax rules mean for the salaried

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It is now well-known that the Income-tax Act, 2025 is all set to take effect from April 1, 2026. While the Act is the primary legislation, procedural details are contained in the 'Rules' accompanying the Act.

Accordingly, the government had made the draft of the Income-tax Rules, 2026 (new IT Rules) public recently. It will receive stakeholders' feedback up to February 22. The final draft, also effective from April 1, will be notified on a later date.

From a personal taxation point of view, a reading of the draft rules reveals noteworthy changes to how perquisites (perks) and allowances of a salaried individual will be taxed hereon. The changes broadly pertain to how perks will be valued and the thresholds for taxability/exemption. These, in the extant rules have not been updated in a long time and thus, have been revised in the new IT rules to reflect contemporary prices and realities. While some of the revisions are beneficial for the taxpayer, some are detrimental. Read on to find out how each impacts your take home pay.

THRESHOLD FOR PERKS
Perks are non-monetary benefits given to an employee, such as free food, free/subsidised medical treatment, rent-free accommodation, so on and so forth. These are valued according to the IT Rules and added to the income of an employee. The extant provisions exempt the value of a benefit/amenity (received free of cost or subsidised), when received by an employee whose cash salary does not exceed ₹50,000 per annum. This threshold has now been hiked to ₹4 lakh per annum.

OVERSEAS TREATMENT
This relates to cost of overseas medical treatment of the employee or his family member borne by the employer. While the provisions as to the cost of treatment and overseas stay remain the same, the new IT rules tweak the provisions relating to the travel for such treatment. The extant provisions exempt travel cost from being treated as a taxable perk only if the employee's gross annual income does not exceed ₹2 lakh. The new IT rules

take this threshold higher to ₹8 lakh.

USE OF COMPANY CAR
It is common for employers/companies to lend a car to employees. The cars may be owned or leased by the company and employees could use them for both official and private purposes. As the costs of running/owning a car have gone up significantly since the last time the extant rules were updated, the new IT Rules have bumped up the valuation of this perk. There could be various permutations based on who owns the car, who bears the running costs and purpose for which it is used – official/personal/both. Here we focus on four cases where there is a change in valuation per the new IT Rules.

Case A: Car is owned/leased by the company, costs borne by the company, employee uses it for both personal and official purposes

Per the extant rules, this perk is valued at ₹1,800 per month if it is a small car (engine capacity up to 1.6 litres) and ₹2,400 per month if it is a big car (engine capacity exceeds 1.6 litres). There is an additional ₹900 per month, if the company bears the driver's salary.

Now, the new rules value the perk at ₹5,000 per month for a small car and ₹7,000 per month for a big car. Driver's salary is valued at ₹3,000 per month.

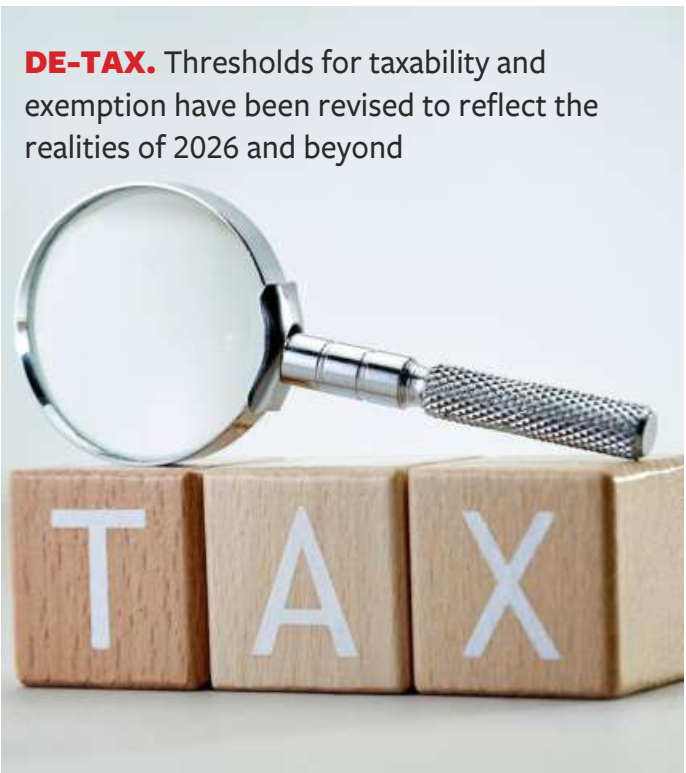
Case B: Car is owned/leased by the company, employee uses it for both personal and official purposes

Currently, valuation in this case is ₹600 per month for a small car and ₹900 per month for a big car. Driver's salary at an additional ₹900 per month.

The new IT Rules value the perk at a higher ₹2,000 per month for a small car and ₹3,000 per month for a big car. Driver's salary borne by the company is valued at ₹3,000 per month – same as in case A.

Case C: Car is owned by the employee, costs are borne by the company, employee uses it for both personal and official purposes

Valuation under the extant rules stands as follows – for a small car: actual cost to the company minus ₹1,800 per month minus ₹900 per month (if driver provided); for a big car: actual



cost to the company minus ₹2,400 per month minus ₹900 per month (if driver provided).

Now, under the new rules, for a small car: actual cost to the company minus ₹5,000 per month minus ₹3,000 per month (if driver provided); for a big car: actual cost to the company minus ₹7,000 per month minus ₹3,000 per month (if driver provided).

Case D: Employee owns a vehicle other than a car, uses it for both personal and official purposes, costs are borne by the company

This case typically applies for employees who use two-wheelers. Value of the perk under current rules: actual cost to the company minus ₹900 per month. This shifts to – actual cost to the company minus ₹3,000 per month under the new rules.

INTEREST-FREE LOANS
It is common for employees to get interest-free loans or loans at subsidised rates from their employers. Such a perk is valued at a notional interest – calculated using interest rate charged by State Bank of India on a similar loan. Any interest paid by the employee is deducted from this notional interest.

This valuation logic is carried forward in the new rules as well.

QUICK FACTS

- Employer loans up to ₹2 lakh not a taxable perk
- Company gifts up to ₹15,000 now exempt
- New cities to get higher HRA exemption

However, if aggregate loans borrowed by the employee from his employer does not exceed ₹20,000, the perk is not taxable at all. This threshold moves up to ₹2 lakh under the new IT Rules.

GIFTS, VOUCHERS, TOKENS
The extant rules exempt the value of gifts, vouchers or tokens received by the employee from his employer on ceremonial occasions, if aggregate value does not exceed ₹5,000 per annum. The threshold per the new IT Rules is ₹15,000 per annum.

FREE FOOD
Currently, free/subsidised food and beverages (non-alcoholic) provided by employer during working hours on premises or food vouchers does not qualify as a taxable perk if the value per meal does not exceed ₹50. This becomes ₹200 per meal under the new rules.

How the old and new regimes compare after the new IT Rules

Jessie, 35, is assumed to live in Hyderabad, working for a private company. She has a minor son.

	Old regime under old IT Rules	Old regime under new IT Rules	New regime under new IT Rules
Basic salary + DA	18,00,000	18,00,000	18,00,000
Less: Standard deduction	-50,000	-50,000	-75,000
House rent allowance (HRA)	10,00,000	10,00,000	10,00,000
Less: Exemption (40%/ 50% of basic + DA)	-7,20,000	-9,00,000	NA
Child education allowance	1,50,000	1,50,000	1,50,000
Less: Exemption (up to ₹100/ ₹3,000 per month)	-1,200	-36,000	NA
Child hostel allowance	50,000	50,000	50,000
Less: Exemption (up to ₹300/ ₹9,000 per month)	-3,600	-50,000	NA
Perquisite value of using employer's car*	32,400	96,000	96,000
Cash gift from the company on the occasion of her birthday	12,000	12,000	12,000
Less: Exemption (taxable value is nil if gift is under ₹5,000/ ₹15,000)**	NA	-12,000	-12,000
Other allowances	5,00,000	5,00,000	5,00,000
Gross total income	27,69,600	25,60,000	35,21,000
Less: Investment in PPF (section 80C/ 123)	-1,50,000	-1,50,000	NA
Less: Investment in NPS (section 80CCD/ 124)	-50,000	-50,000	NA
Less: Medical insurance premium (section 80D/ 126)	-25,000	-25,000	NA
Total income	25,44,600	23,35,000	35,21,000
Tax liability before cess	5,75,880	5,13,000	6,36,300

Old regime under old and new IT Rules are compared to observe the impact of higher exemption for allowances. Since exemption for allowances are anyway not available under the new regime, comparison with old IT Rules not carried out.
*Car (engine size of 1.5 litres) is used for both official and private purposes. All costs thereon, including driver's salary are borne by the company. Perquisite value is ₹2,700 per month under old IT Rules and ₹8,000 per month under new rules.
**'Gift value does not fall under ₹5,000, the whole amount becomes taxable under the old regime per old IT Rules - bl, portfolio calculations

LEAVE TRAVEL ASSISTANCE

Leave travel assistance (LTA) is taxed as gross value of LTA minus exemption (calculated as per IT Rules). The provisions to value the exemption largely remain the same under the new rules, except in two cases. In case of journey by air, currently, the exemption works out to the price of economy class ticket offered by the national carrier. Now that Air India has been sold to Tata Sons, the new rules cap the exemption at the fare admissible for the class of travel to which the employee is entitled. While it appears that the company's own by-laws might decide in which class an employee is entitled to fly, more clarity is expected on this front.

In case of a journey where the source and destination are not connected by air, rail or any other means of recognised public transport, the extant rules cap the ex-

emption at a notional and equivalent rail fare for a journey in first class A/C. The new rules simplify the calculation of exemption to ₹30 per km.

HOUSE RENT ALLOWANCE

Currently, the exemption for house rent allowance (HRA) is calculated as the minimum of:

- Actual HRA
- Actual rent paid minus one-tenth of salary (typically, basic + dearness allowance)
- 50 per cent of salary (basic + DA) for employees residing in Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata or Chennai; 40 per cent of salary for other employees.

Under the new IT Rules, a and b have been retained. Under c though, employees who are residents of Bengaluru, Pune, Ahmedabad and Hyderabad – will now be eligible for an exemption up to 50 per cent of salary.

CHILDREN ALLOWANCE

Under the extant rules, exemption for children's education allowance is capped at ₹100 per month per child for a maximum of two children. In line with the rising cost of education, this has now been hiked to ₹3,000 per month per child, for maximum two children. Similarly, the exemption for children's hostel allowance is capped at ₹300 per month per child for a maximum of two children. Under the new rules, it stands capped at ₹9,000 per month per child, for maximum two children.

TRANSPORT WORKER ALLOWANCE

The new IT rules now introduce an exemption against allowance received by an employee of any transport system (drivers, loco pilots, guards) to meet personal expenses. This exemption is capped at a minimum of ₹25,000 per month or 70 per cent of such allowance.

OTHER EXEMPTIONS

These apart, exemption caps against a range of allowances have been raised substantially, under the new rules. These include allowances for the armed forces such as Siachen allowance, high altitude allowance, island duty allowance and so on. These apart, allowances such as underground allowance for mine workers, transport allowance for the physically challenged, special compensatory allowance for those posted in the hill-States, among others, account for the rest.

WHICH REGIME THEN?

The aforementioned provisions for perks (all sub-heads until free food) apply to both the old and new regimes. However, as far as allowances are concerned (LTA onwards), the exemptions apply only to those taxpayers opting for the old regime. That said, it is difficult to simply declare the old regime to be more attractive than the new regime or vice versa. The upgraded exemptions target a certain class of employees (armed forces, for instance) or certain kinds of exemptions (child education allowance, for example). If your pay includes a sizeable portion of these allowances, it might make sense to switch to the old regime. Work out your tax liability changes or consult a tax expert to make an informed decision.

Valuables in locker missing? What next

GUARDING WEALTH. The bank is liable for compensation only in case of clear security lapse or employee misdemeanour

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One of India's favourite precious metal is gold and is used for multiple purposes such as investments, raising loans, jewellery and so forth.

Availing loans by pledging gold ornaments and jewellery at financial institutions is very common.

As is the fact of households being known to stash their family gold in bank lockers for safe keeping.

Though these are generally safe avenues as far as your gold is concerned, recent events may raise concerns.

Apart from gold, many customers hold property documents, investment certificates and the like.

A few days ago, a customer complained that gold worth ₹60 lakh was missing from the locker maintained with a leading public sector bank.

Police investigation is underway in the case with no clear culprit identified yet.

Late last year, an NRI customer found that her gold coins and jewellery were missing from a leading private bank's locker in a Chennai branch.

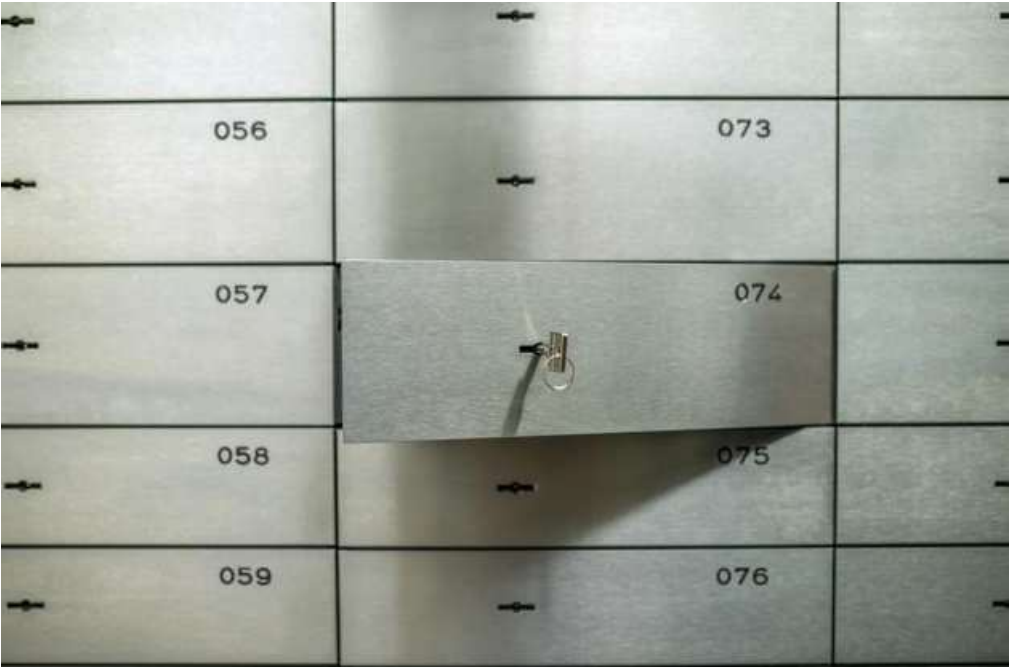
The case was finally cracked by the police and the bank official was arrested.

More recently, a woman who had pledged her gold ornaments for loans and came to redeem them after repayment found several pieces missing.

The police investigated and found that the public sector bank's assistant manager was skimming small portions of gold pledged by customers for loans.

While some of these cases had happy closures, as a bank locker or gold loan customer, you must be aware of the steps to take after a loss, your potential liabilities and compensation in the case of a loss.

We discuss these aspects alongside locker and jewellery



insurance to cover potential losses.

CUSTOMER RECOURSE

Let us take the case of gold or any other valuable items going missing from your locker.

It is assumed, as a customer, your locker operations are active (regularly used) and the annual rent is paid. The locker agreement (between the bank and the customer) is assumed to be current and active.

As a customer, you must also be aware that the bank employees would not be aware of the contents you keep in your locker. The employee who accompanies you to your locker opens it with the bank key and leaves the room immediately.

In case you notice gold or other valuables missing during your visits, you must inform the bank manager immediately. A written report from your side detailing the locker contents is necessary. You must also formally request for CCTV access.

It is also advisable to have pictures of your gold jewellery or

CAUTION ADVISED

RBI expressly prohibits holding cash in lockers. If any cash in a locker is lost, the bank would not pay any compensation

other valuables as they are placed in the locker periodically to support your claims.

The bank will conduct an inquiry into the matter. However, the bank is liable for compensation only if a clear lapse is established in its security infrastructure or in case of employee misdemeanour.

In addition to the bank manager, you must also get the police involved. Filing an FIR (First Information Report) is necessary.

The police will then conduct their own investigation into the matter within and outside the bank.

In case your gold jewellery or valuables are not recovered after establishing that you indeed did keep them in the

locker, and a lapse is established from the bank's side, you will be entitled to compensation.

However, the compensation amount has no relation to the value of your jewellery or other precious items you stored in the locker.

The amount is restricted to 100 times the annual rent amount paid by you for the bank locker.

So, the maximum relief you can get if you pay ₹5,000 as annual rent is ₹5 lakh even if your valuables may be worth a lot more. You will henceforth have to bear the losses in such cases.

Then there is the case of gold going missing when pledged to a bank for a loan.

So, while redeeming your gold, if you notice pieces missing, you must immediately inform the bank or NBFC branch manager.

As it is the lending institution's responsibility to safely store your gold in the original form as received during the pledging process, the onus lies with the bank or NBFC to com-

pensate. The bank itself would have pictures of the pledged gold, though, it would be a good idea to have the images with you.

It would also be better to file an FIR with the police in this case.

If the lost gold is not retrievable, the bank or NBFC is obliged to pay the current market value of the jewellery that went missing going by recent judicial precedents.

You can approach the RBI ombudsman, and later the courts, if you find the bank unresponsive.

One critical aspect to note is that the RBI expressly prohibits holding cash in lockers. If any cash in a locker is lost, the bank would not pay any compensation. You will have to hope for the police to find the culprits in such cases.

INSURING VALUABLES

If you choose to keep gold or jewellery in your bank locker, you can take an insurance policy to secure your valuables. In addition to theft, the jewellery insurance covers loss due to earthquakes, floods, fire and other natural disasters that can cause damage to lockers at bank branches leading to loss of contents.

IFFCO-Tokio offers an exclusive bank locker protector policy. HDFC Ergo, Oriental Insurance and SBI General cover jewellery loss due to theft, fraud, natural disasters and so forth.

You can get your gold valued by a jeweller and provide the details to your insurer at the time of taking the policy. Pictures of the jewellery may also be useful or even compulsory in some cases.

One point to note is if you receive compensation from your insurer for any jewellery lost and if the valuables are later found by the police or bank and handed back to you, there is an obligation on you to return the amount to the insurer.

Bank FD interest rates (%)

Bank	<1 year	1 to 2 years	2 to 3 years	3 to 5 years	w.e.f
FOREIGN BANKS					
DBS Bank	6	6.6	6.4	6.4	Nov 14
Deutsche Bank	5	7	6.25	6.25	Jul 25
HSBC	4.1	5.5	5.35	5.5	Jul 17
Scotia Bank	3.7	3.9	4	4	Dec 01
Standard Chartered	5.75	6.6	6.5	6.5	Aug 29
INDIAN: PUBLIC SECTOR BANKS					
Bank of Maharashtra	5.25	6.65	5.25	5.25	Jan 07
Bank of Baroda	6	6.6	6.5	6.4	Jun 12
Bank of India	5.5	6.7	6.3	6.25	Dec 01
Canara Bank	5.5	6.5	6.25	6.25	Jan 05
Central Bank of India	5	6.2	6.25	6	Dec 10
Indian Bank	4.75	6.45	6.15	6.05	Feb 04
Indian Overseas Bank	5.5	6.6	6.4	6.1	Dec 15
Punjab National Bank	5.6	6.4	6.3	6.1	Feb 01
Punjab & Sind Bank	4.85	6.75	6	5.95	Feb 16
State Bank of India	5.9	6.45	6.4	6.3	Dec 15
UCO Bank	6.3	6.45	6.1	6	Dec 11
Union Bank	6.1	6.6	6.25	6	Feb 11
INDIAN: PRIVATE SECTOR BANKS					
Axis Bank	5.75	6.45	6.45	6.45	Feb 20
Bandhan Bank	4.20	7.2	7.2	7	Sep 12
CSB Bank	6.75	7	6.5	5.75	Sep 10
City Union Bank	6.25	7	6.5	6.25	Jan 14
DCB Bank	6.5	7	7	7.15	Jan 16
Dhanlaxmi Bank	6.6	6.95	6.5	6.5	Nov 28
Federal Bank	6	6.5	6.7	6.4	Feb 16
HDFC Bank	5.75	6.45	6.45	6.4	Dec 17
ICICI Bank	5.5	6.3	6.45	6.5	Feb 20
IDBI Bank	5.8	6.5	6.55	6.35	Dec 18
IDFC First Bank	5.5	7	7	7	Nov 04
IndusInd Bank	6.25	7	6.9	6.65	Sep 25
J & K Bank	6	6.75	7.25	6.65	Feb 11
Karnataka Bank	5.75	6.65	6.15	6.15	Aug 01
Kotak Bank	6	6.7	6.7	6.4	Feb 11
Karur Vysya Bank	6.65	6.55	6.55	6.55	Sep 26
RBL Bank	6.05	7.2	7.2	7	Sep 24
South Indian Bank	5.9	6.6	6.2	6.2	Jan 14
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.4	7.1	6.6	6.6	Jan 08
TNSC Bank	6.6	7.35	6.85	6.6	NA
Yes Bank	6.5	7	7	7	Dec 01
SMALL FINANCE BANKS					
Equitas Small Finance Bank	6.35	6.9	7.2	7	Feb 02
ESAF Small Finance Bank	4.75	7.6	7.25	6	Jun 18
Jana Small Finance Bank	7	7.25	7.5	7.77	Jan 10
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	6.5	7.5	7.25	7.9	05-Feb
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	6	7.5	7.5	7.25	Dec 01
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	6	7.45	7.25	7.2	05-Aug

Data as on respective banks' website on 20 Feb 2026; For each year range, the maximum offered interest rate is considered; interest rate is for a normal fixed deposit amount below ₹1 crore. Compiled by BankBazaar.com;



bl rating	Scheme Name	Latest NAV (₹)	Latest Corpus (₹ Cr)	Expense Ratio (%)		Trailing Returns (%)				Sortino Ratio (%)
				Regular	Direct	1 Year CAGR	3 Year CAGR	5 Year CAGR	10 Year CAGR	

EQUITY - LARGE CAP FUNDS

*****	Canara Robeco Large Cap	63.6	17092	1.7	0.5	10.6	15.1	12.2	15.4	0.43
*****	ICICI Pru Large Cap	113.5	76646	1.4	0.9	13.3	18.0	15.6	16.0	0.60
*****	Nippon Ind Large Cap	93.0	50107	1.5	0.7	14.4	19.1	17.5	16.3	0.64
*****	HDFC Large Cap	1167.1	39621	1.6	1.0	10.7	15.9	14.4	15.3	0.54
*****	JM Large Cap	156.7	444	2.4	0.9	11.2	15.3	13.2	12.5	0.42
*****	Kotak Large Cap	587.7	10864	1.7	0.6	13.7	15.4	13.1	14.3	0.46
*****	SBI Large Cap	95.4	54821	1.5	0.8	13.6	14.5	12.5	13.8	0.46
***	Aditya Birla SL Large Cap	534.2	30392	1.6	1.0	12.2	15.5	13.2	13.9	0.47
***	Bandhan Large Cap	79.1	1980	2.0	0.9	14.8	17.5	13.1	14.2	0.42
***	Baroda BNP Paribas Large Cap	224.6	2614	2.0	0.8	11.2	16.1	13.1	14.1	0.44
***	Edelweiss Large Cap	86.4	1444	2.1	0.6	12.2	15.3	12.9	14.4	0.44
***	Franklin Ind Large Cap	1038.7	7704	1.9	1.1	11.2	14.7	11.2	12.5	0.39
***	Groww Large Cap	69.7	1666	2.0	0.7	13.5	17.4	14.0	14.0	0.45
***	Mirae Asset Large Cap	114.8	40371	1.5	0.5	12.6	13.3	11.5	14.9	0.39
***	Tata Large Cap	518.3	2760	2.0	1.0	12.3	15.5	13.2	13.5	0.47
***	UTI Large Cap	275.7	12839	1.8	0.9	8.2	12.8	11.1	13.3	0.36
**	DSP Large Cap	479.2	7163	1.8	0.9	9.8	17.8	13.5	13.5	0.48
**	HSBC Large Cap	493.5	1885	2.1	1.3	13.0	15.8	12.1	14.3	0.37
**	LIC MF Large Cap	55.9	1434	2.2	1.1	10.8	11.9	10.0	12.2	0.30
**	Union Largecap	23.8	458	2.5	1.7	11.0	13.1	11.2	-	0.36
**	Axis Large Cap	61.3	32420	1.6	0.7	9.5	12.7	9.1	13.6	0.25
*	Groww Largecap	44.3	129	2.5	1.3	15.5	14.8	11.7	13.0	0.36
*	PGIM India Large Cap	340.3	570	2.4	0.9	10.1	11.4	9.6	11.7	0.29
*	Mah Manu Large Cap	23.5	740	2.3	0.6	11.4	14.7	12.1	-	0.42
-	Taurus Large Cap	160.5	51	2.6	2.3	12.1	17.2	12.4	11.7	0.35

EQUITY - LARGE & MID CAP FUNDS

*****	Bandhan Large & Mid Cap	137.9	13968	1.7	0.5	15.6	23.3	19.4	17.4	0.64
*****	HDFC Large and Mid Cap	343.4	28240	1.6	0.8	13.6	20.2	18.5	16.4	0.64
*****	ICICI Pru Large & Mid Cap	1038.4	27445	1.6	0.8	14.6	21.3	20.3	17.3	0.80
*****	Axis Large & Mid Cap	33.2	15287	1.7	0.6	12.5	19.4	15.9	-	0.48
*****	Quant Large & Mid Cap	107.9	3039	2.0	0.8	1.6	14.8	16.6	16.4	0.46
*****	SBI Large & Midcap	653.2	37497	1.6	0.7	17.2	18.9	17.7	16.7	0.65
*****	UTI Large & Mid Cap	184.9	5615	1.9	0.9	14.0	22.0	18.7	15.8	0.66
***	BOI Large & Mid Cap Equity	89.9	446	2.3	1.1	15.3	17.0	15.5	14.1	0.47
***	Canara Robeco Large and Mid Cap	247.1	24644	1.6	0.6	8.1	15.8	13.6	16.7	0.44
***	DSP Large & Mid Cap	637.4	17434	1.7	0.6	13.8	20.8	16.7	17.1	0.58
***	Edelweiss Large & Mid Cap	88.4	4442	1.8	0.4	13.7	18.6	15.4	16.0	0.51
***	Invesco India Large & Mid Cap	99.2	8959	1.8	0.6	16.0	24.4	17.5	17.1	0.51
***	Kotak Large & Midcap	356.9	29991	1.6	0.6	17.9	19.9	17.3	17.3	0.58
***	Mirae Asset Large & Midcap	154.8	42275	1.5	0.6	17.3	17.7	14.5	18.8	0.47
***	Nippon Ind Vision Large & Mid Cap	1487.3	6751	1.9	1.2	13.2	21.2	17.2	14.7	0.58
***	Franklin Ind Large & Mid Cap	188.5	3518	2.0	1.3	10.7	16.6	13.5	13.0	0.44
***	LIC MF Large & Midcap	38.4	2993	1.9	0.6	10.7	17.8	14.9	16.1	0.47
***	Sundaram Large and Mid Cap	87.6	6735	1.8	0.7	14.7	17.2	14.8	15.5	0.46
***	Tata Large & Mid Cap	506.5	8123	1.8	0.7	7.1	12.8	12.6	14.3	0.45
*	Aditya Birla Large & Mid Cap	923.7	5654	1.9	1.1	15.6	16.0	11.1	13.4	0.29
*	Navi Large & Midcap	35.4	302	2.3	0.5	10.1	13.6	13.1	14.3	0.43
-	HSBC Large & Mid Cap	27.5	4603	1.9	0.8	17.2	20.8	16.0	-	0.40

EQUITY - FLEXI CAP FUNDS

*****	HDFC Flexi Cap	2079.9	97452	1.3	0.7	15.9	22.2	20.4	18.7	0.83
*****	JM Flexicap	95.4	5152	1.8	0.6	4.6	19.9	17.4	17.9	0.54
*****	Parag Parikh Flexi Cap	80.0	133970	1.3	0.6	7.5	20.0	17.5	18.3	0.71
*****	Edelweiss Flexi Cap	39.3	3133	1.9	0.4	14.6	19.0	15.7	16.4	0.51
*****	Franklin Ind Flexi Cap	1646.5	19528	1.7	0.9	10.6	18.7	16.1	15.1	0.54
*****	PGIM India Flexi Cap	36.0	6022	1.8	0.5	10.5	12.9	12.1	15.1	0.37
*****	Union Flexi Cap	51.6	2320	2.0	0.9	13.2	15.8	13.7	14.6	0.45
***	Aditya Birla SL Flexi Cap	1862.6	24700	1.7	0.9	16.3	18.4	14.6	15.9	0.47
***	Bandhan Flexi Cap	211.1	7478	1.9	1.1	12.2	15.9	13.7	12.6	0.44
***	Canara Robeco Flexi Cap	343.3	13327	1.7	0.6	13.4	15.5	13.1	15.8	0.44
***	DSP Flexi Cap	103.9	11989	1.8	0.9	11.9	17.2	13.4	15.8	0.42
***	HSBC Flexi Cap	217.9	5318	1.9	1.2	12.9	18.8	14.9	14.6	0.43
***	Kotak Flexicap	87.9	56479	1.4	0.6	17.6	17.6	14.1	15.6	0.47
***	SBI Flexicap	110.8	23148	1.7	0.8	10.1	13.7	11.6	14.0	0.40
***	Tata Flexi Cap	24.5	3630	1.9	0.6	12.2	17.1	12.7	-	0.42
**	Axis Flexi Cap	26.5	12639	1.7	0.7	12.9	15.2	10.8	-	0.30
**	Motilal Oswal Flexi Cap	57.4	13180	1.7	0.8	3.7	21.5	12.8	13.9	0.37
**	Navi Flexi Cap	23.6	253	2.2	0.6	14.9	13.6	12.3	-	0.39
**	UTI Flexi Cap	305.5	23542	1.7	1.1	1.8	10.2	7.6	12.9	0.20
**	LIC MF Flexi Cap	98.7	1010	2.3	1.6	12.2	14.5	11.4	11.6	0.33
**	Shriram Flexi Cap	20.1	132	2.4	0.8	7.1	10.8	9.7	-	0.24
**	Taurus Flexi Cap	221.8	342	2.7	2.6	5.8	14.9	11.8	11.3	0.35
-	Quant Flexi Cap	96.7	6221	1.8	0.7	10.0	17.4	20.1	19.8	0.55

EQUITY - MULTI CAP FUNDS

-	Baroda BNP Paribas Multi Cap	282.5	3048	2.0	0.9	8.4	18.0	16.6	15.4	0.49
-	ICICI Pru Multicap	805.3	15845	1.7	0.9	12.0	20.2	17.1	16.1	0.61
-	Invesco India Multicap	123.3	3934	1.9	0.7	5.0	16.6	14.3	14.8	0.42
-	Mah Manu Multi Cap	35.9	6046	1.8	0.4	15.0	20.8	18.7	-	0.55
-	Nippon Ind Multi Cap	299.3	48809	1.5	0.7	15.0	21.9	21.8	16.9	0.73
-	Quant Multi Cap	580.7	7456	1.8	0.7	1.3	11.1	15.2	17.5	0.40
-	Sundaram Multi Cap	381.7	2798	2.0	0.9	13.0	17.7	16.1	16.7	0.51

EQUITY - MID CAP FUNDS

*****	Edelweiss Mid Cap	103.2	13802	1.7	0.4	17.5	25.7	21.5	19.8	0.65
*****	HDFC Mid Cap	202.7	92187	1.4	0.7	18.6	25.9	22.9	19.7	0.79
*****	Quant Mid Cap	196.1	7283	1.8	0.8	-2.0	14.3	19.9	16.4	0.54
*****	Invesco India Midcap	179.8	10058	1.7	0.5	20.1	26.8	21.0	19.5	0.60
*****	Mah Manu Mid Cap	34.1	4267	1.9	0.5	15.7	24.8	21.3	-	0.62
*****	Motilal Oswal Midcap	91.7	34432	1.6	0.8	-1.7	22.3	23.3	17.5	0.65
*****	Nippon Ind Growth Mid Cap	4307.8	41727	1.5	0.7	19.1	26.2	22.7	20.1	0.70
***	Axis Midcap	113.3	30895	1.6	0.6	14.8	19.3	16.1	17.9	0.48
***	Baroda BNP Paribas Mid Cap	105.2	2282	2.0	0.5	15.7	21.4	18.4	16.8	0.58
***	ICICI Pru Midcap	319.8	6969	1.9	1.0	25.2	25.1	20.8	17.9	0.63
***	Kotak Midcap	136.2	59041	1.4	0.4	17.2	21.4	19.5	19.3	0.61
***	PGIM India Midcap	62.8	10751	1.7	0.5	10.1	13.4	15.3	16.7	0.48
***	SBI Midcap	234.5	22424	1.7	0.9	9.6	17.1	17.2	15.7	0.59
***	Sundaram Mid Cap	1425.4	12917	1.7	0.9	18.3	24.9	20.0	16.7	0.51
***	Tata Mid Cap	447.2	5356	1.8	0.7	17.8	22.2	18.5	17.7	0.68
**	Aditya Birla SL Midcap	789.7	6041	1.9	1.0	15.1	20.5	18.1	15.3	0.55
**	Franklin Ind Mid Cap	2733.0	12223	1.8	1.0	11.8	22.0	16.9	16.3	0.51
**	Taurus Mid Cap	116.1	123	2.5	1.9	9.4	15.2	14.4	16.2	0.41
**	UTI Mid Cap	298.0	11493	1.8	0.9	12.6	17.1	15.7	15.5	0.46
**	DSP Midcap	149.7	19047	1.7	0.8	17.1	20.8	14.7	16.5	0.43
**	HSBC Midcap	403.1	12175	1.7	0.7	20.9	25.0	19.0	17.9	0.50
**	LIC MF Midcap	28.4	331	2.5	1.4	8.8	20.3	14.8	-	0.42

EQUITY - SMALL CAP FUNDS

*****	Nippon Ind Small Cap	162.9	65812	1.4	0.7	10.3	20.8	23.5	21.6	0.64
*****	Quant Small Cap	239.1	27384	1.6	0.8	6.1	19.0	24.7	18.3	0.61
*****	AXIS Small Cap	102.9	25517	1.6	0.6	11.2	17.5	19.5	19.0	0.60
*****	BOI Small Cap	44.0	1829	2.0	0.5	8.6	19.1	19.6	-	0.49

bl rating	Scheme Name	Latest NAV (₹)	Latest Corpus (₹ Cr)	Expense Ratio (%)		Trailing Returns (%)				Sortino Ratio (%)
				Regular	Direct	1 Year CAGR	3 Year CAGR	5 Year CAGR	10 Year CAGR	

★★★★★	Invesco India Smallcap	41.3	9009	1.7	0.4	14.0	24.1	22.2	-	0.59
★★★★★	DSP Small Cap	194.6	16135	1.7	0.8	15.3	20.4	20.4	18.0	0.55
★★★★★	HDFC Small Cap	134.3	36941	1.5	0.7	11.4	18.3	20.8	19.2	0.61
★★★★★	ICICI Pru Smallcap	84.3	8123	1.8	0.8	10.4	16.8	19.0	16.8	0.64
★★★★★	Kotak Small Cap	244.8	16368	1.7	0.6	6.2	14.6	16.5	17.9	0.47
★★★★★	Sundaram Small Cap	255.1	3285	1.9	0.8	15.3	19.9	20.0	15.7	0.54
★★★★★	Tata Small Cap	34.7	10761	1.7	0.4	-2.0	14.1	19.2	-	0.56
★★★★★	Union Small Cap	49.6	1697	2.1	1.0	18.8	19.7	19.1	16.7	0.48
★★★	Franklin Ind Small Cap	162.4	12764	1.8	1.0	7.7	19.0	19.8	16.4	0.53
★★★	HSBC Small Cap	76.3	15029	1.7	0.7	5.8	16.7	21.4	19.1	0.52
★★★	SBI Small Cap	161.9	34449	1.6	0.8	6.3	13.2	15.9	18.3	0.49
★★★	Aditya Birla SL Small Cap	84.9	4778	1.9	0.9	15.8	18.2	15.6	14.4	0.41
★★★	LIC MF Small Cap	28.7	587	2.4	1.0	3.5	16.8	19.4	-	0.48
-	Canara Robeco Small Cap	37.5	12671	1.7	0.5	9.6	15.9	20.2	-	0.50
-	Edelweiss Small Cap	42.8	5369	1.8	0.5	10.9	19.4	20.1	-	0.69

bl rating	Scheme Name	Latest NAV (₹)	Latest Corpus (₹ Cr)	Expense Ratio (%)		Trailing Returns (%)				AA & Below
				Regular	Direct	1 Month %Ann	3 Month %Ann	6 Month %Ann	1 Year CAGR	
CASH FUNDS										
LIQUID FUNDS										
-	360 ONE Liquid	2083.8	1258	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.7	5.7	6.1	-
-	Aditya Birla SL Liquid	436.6	54615	0.4	0.2	6.5	5.9	5.8	6.4	-
-	Axis Liquid	3017.3	39028	0.2	0.1	6.6	5.9	5.9	6.4	-
-	Bandhan Liquid	3270.9	15367	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.2	-
-	Baroda BNP Paribas Liquid	3114.1	12278	0.3	0.1	6.4	5.9	5.8	6.3	-
-	BOI Liquid	3121.5	1843	0.1	0.1	6.6	6.0	5.9	6.4	-
-	Canara Robeco Liquid	3260.8	5794	0.2	0.1	6.6	5.8	5.8	6.4	-
-	DSP Liquidity	3868.5	16616	0.2	0.1	6.6	5.9	5.9	6.4	-
-	Edelweiss Liquid	3465.4	10125	0.2	0.1	6.6	5.9	5.9	6.4	-
-	Groww Liquid	2620.2	169	0.2	0.1	6.6	5.9	5.8	6.4	-
-	HDFC Liquid	5315.5	59966	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.9	5.8	6.3	-
-	HSBC Liquid	2700.9	15975	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	ICICI Pru Liquid	401.0	52165	0.3	0.2	6.3	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	Invesco India Liquid	3723.7	15884	0.2	0.2	6.4	5.9	5.8	6.3	-
-	ITI Liquid	1410.3	57	0.3	0.1	6.3	5.6	5.6	6.2	-
-	JM Liquid	73.9	2703	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.2	0.20
-	Kotak Liquid	5474.4	34938	0.3	0.2	6.4	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	LIC MF Liquid	4896.1	12352	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	Mahi Manu Liquid	1763.2	1159	0.3	0.2	6.6	5.9	5.9	6.3	-
-	Mirae Asset Liquid	2840.4	12122	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	Motilal Oswal Liquid	14.3	1105	0.4	0.2	6.0	5.6	5.5	5.9	-
-	Motilal Oswal Liquid	13.8	1105	-	0.2	6.2	5.8	5.7	6.1	-
-	Navil Liquid	29.4	68	0.2	0.2	5.5	5.4	5.5	5.9	6.60
-	Nippon Ind Liquid	6610.9	25994	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	Parag Parikh Liquid	1502.2	4068	0.2	0.1	6.7	5.8	5.8	6.1	-
-	PGIM India Liquid	352.7	546	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.8	5.8	6.4	-
-	Quant Liquid	42.8	1261	0.5	0.2	6.3	5.7	5.6	6.1	-
-	Quantum Liquid	36.2	583	0.3	0.2	6.2	5.6	5.5	5.9	-
-	SBI Liquid	4232.9	59282	0.3	0.2	6.4	5.8	5.8	6.3	-
-	Sundaram Liquid	2387.8	6215	0.4	0.1	6.3	5.7	5.7	6.2	-
-	Tata Liquid	4267.1	21438	0.3	0.2	6.4	5.9	5.8	6.4	-
-	Union Liquid	2607.4	7389	0.2	0.1	6.5	5.9	5.9	6.4	-
-	UTI Liquid	4445.1	24939	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.9	5.9	6.4	-
-	WhiteOak Capital Liquid	1456.2	606	0.3	0.2	6.5	5.8	5.7	6.2	-

ARBITRAGE FUNDS										
-	Aditya Birla SL Arbitrage	27.6	26736	1.0	0.3	6.1	6.1	5.9	6.3	-
-	Axis Arbitrage	19.4	8739	1.0	0.3	6.1	6.1	5.9	6.3	-
-	Bandhan Arbitrage	33.6	8829	1.1	0.4	5.7	5.8	5.6	6.0	-
-	Baroda BNP Paribas Arbitrage	16.6	1370	1.1	0.3	5.7	5.6	5.7	6.0	0.00
-	BOI Arbitrage	14.3	47	0.9	0.4	5.2	5.8	5.6	5.8	-
-	DSP Arbitrage	15.5	6891	1.0	0.4	6.1	6.0	5.8	6.1	-
-	Edelweiss Arbitrage	20.1	15619	1.1	0.4	5.8	6.0	5.8	6.2	-
-	HDFC Arbitrage	31.8	24503	0.9	0.4	6.0	6.2	5.9	6.3	-
-	HSBC Arbitrage	19.7	2419	0.9	0.3	6.2	6.0	5.8	6.1	-
-	ICICI Pru Equity-Arbitrage	35.6	32976	0.9	0.4	6.4	6.3	6.0	6.4	-
-	Invesco India Arbitrage	33.1	28593	1.1	0.4	6.1	6.3	6.0	6.3	0.10
-	ITI Arbitrage	13.5	54	0.9	0.2	6.5	6.4	6.0	6.4	-
-	JM Arbitrage	33.8	376	1.1	0.4	5.8	5.9	5.8	5.8	-
-	Kotak Arbitrage	38.9	71931	1.1	0.4	6.2	6.2	5.9	6.3	-
-	LIC MF Arbitrage	14.3	281	1.0	0.3	6.1	6.0	5.7	6.0	-
-	Mahi Manu Arbitrage	12.8	97	1.1	0.4	6.1	5.8	5.6	5.4	-
-	Mirae Asset Arbitrage	13.5	3639	0.9	0.1	6.1	6.1	5.9	6.0	-
-	Nippon Ind Arbitrage	27.5	16390	1.1	0.4	6.0	6.1	5.9	6.1	1.70
-	PGIM India Arbitrage	19.0	90	1.0	0.4	5.5	5.8	5.6	5.9	-
-	SBI Arbitrage Opport	35.1	43574	0.9	0.4	5.8	6.2	5.9	6.4	-
-	Sundaram Arbitrage	15.0	355	1.0	0.3	6.6	6.2	5.8	6.1	-
-	Tata Arbitrage	14.9	20563	1.1	0.3	5.8	6.3	5.9	6.3	-
-	Union Arbitrage	14.5	290	1.0	0.4	5.7	5.7	5.6	5.9	-
-	UTI Arbitrage	36.4	10957	0.8	0.3	6.4	6.3	6.1	6.4	-

bl rating	Scheme Name	Latest NAV (₹)	Latest Corpus (₹ Cr)	Expense Ratio (%)		Trailing Returns (%)				AA & Below (%)
				Regular	Direct	1 Year CAGR	2 Year CAGR	3 Year CAGR	5 Year CAGR	
DEBT FUNDS										
DEBT - ULTRA SHORT DURATION FUNDS										
*****	Aditya Birla SL Savings	570.5	22857	0.6	0.3	7.2	7.4	7.4	6.3	11.23
*****	Baroda BNP Paribas Ultra Short Dur	1600.8	797	0.5	0.3	6.7	7.1	7.2	6.1	1.89
*****	Nippon Ind Ultra Short Duration	4180.4	10488	1.1	0.4	6.6	6.9	6.9	6.7	29.38
*****	Bandhan Ultra Short Duration	15.8	3566	0.5	0.3	6.7	7.0	7.1	5.9	-
*****	ICICI Pru Ultra Short Term	28.8	17808	0.8	0.4	6.9	7.1	7.1	6.0	11.19
*****	Mirae Asset Ultra Short Duration	1359.1	1852	0.5	0.2	6.9	7.2	7.2	6.1	1.63
*****	UTI Ultra Short Duration	4393.1	3879	1.0	0.3	6.4	6.8	6.8	6.2	11.07
*****	Axis Ultra Short Duration	15.3	5894	1.2	0.4	6.4	6.7	6.7	5.5	11.02
*****	DSP Ultra Short	3525.0	3547	1.0	0.3	6.4	6.7	6.7	5.5	10.89
*****	HDFC Ultra Short Term	15.7	17353	0.7	0.4	6.7	7.0	7.0	5.9	4.16
*****	HSBC Ultra Short Duration	1405.3	3045	0.3	0.2	6.7	7.1	7.1	5.9	-
*****	Invesco India Ultra Short Duration	2796.2	1315	0.8	0.2	6.5	6.9	6.9	5.7	11.35
*****	Kotak Savings	44.5	16788	0.8	0.4	6.7	6.9	6.9	5.8	8.29
*****	Mahi Manu Ultra Short Duration	1426.4	210	0.7	0.3	6.5	6.9	6.9	5.8	3.57
*****	SBI Ultra Short Duration	6205.1	14032	0.6	0.4	6.8	7.1	7.1	5.9	8.00
*****	WhiteOak Capital Ultra Short Dur	1407.7	550	1.0	0.5	6.1	6.5	6.5	5.4	-
*****	BOI Ultra Short Duration	3272.0	168	0.9	0.3	6.2	6.4	6.4	5.4	12.55
*****	LIC MF Ultra Short Duration	1367.3	246	0.5	0.2	6.1	6.5	6.4	5.4	2.15
*****	PGIM India Ultra Short Duration	35.2	179	0.9	0.5	6.1	6.5	6.5	5.5	-
*****	Tata Ultra Short Term	14.7	4549	1.2	0.3	6.3	6.6	6.6	5.5	10.45
*****	Canara Robeco Ultra Short Term	3930.4	501	1.0	0.4	6.2	6.5	6.5	5.3	-
*****	Motilal Oswal Ultra Short Term	17.0	500	1.0	0.2	5.3	5.6	5.7	4.7	-
*****	Sundaram Ultra Short Duration	2770.2	1838	1.4	0.2	5.7	6.0	6.1	5.0	1.69

DEBT - LOW DURATION FUNDS										
*****	ICICI Pru Savings	566.5	31616	0.6	0.4	7.4	7.7	7.7	6.4	8.64
*****	UTI Low Duration	3691.7	2965	0.4	0.3	7.3	7.4	7.4	7.2	8.28
*****	Axis Treasury Advantage	3218.4	7716	0.7	0.4	7.2	7.4	7.4	6.1	8.00
*****	DSP Low Duration	20.6	5662	0.6	0.3	6.8	7.1	7.1	5.9	-
*****	HDFC Low Duration	59.9	24846	1.1	0.5	7.0	7.2	7.2	5.9	11.28
*****	HSBC Low Duration	29.8	997	0.9	0.4	8.3	7.8	7.6	6.2	12.66
*****	Aditya Birla SL Low Duration	680.5	14456	1.2	0.4	6.7	6.9	6.9	5.8	9.49
*****	Bandhan Low Duration	40.0	5927	0.7	0.3	6.8	7.1	7.1	5.9	-
*****	Canara Robeco Savings	43.8	1367	0.5	0.2	7.0	7.1	7.1	5.8	-
*****	Invesco India Low Duration	3927.4	1981	0.7	0.3	6.9	7.1	7.1	5.9	8.71
*****	JM Low Duration	38.5	198	0.9	0.4	6.9	7.1	7.0	5.7	6.32
*****	Nippon Ind Low Duration	3887.4	10508	1.0	0.4	6.9	7.2	7.1	6.0	9.60
*****	SBI Low Duration	3621.1	17199	0.9	0.4	6.8	7.0	7.0	5.7	1.62
*****	Tata Treasury Advantage	4079.8	3752	0.6	0.2	6.9	7.1	7.1	5.9	3.32
*****	Kotak Low Duration	3465.3	14796	1.2	0.4	6.7	7.0	7.0	5.8	11.80
*****	Mahi Manu Low Duration	1693.9	582	1.1	0.3	6.6	6.9	6.9	5.6	14.88
*****	Mirae Asset Low Duration	2342.2	2677	0.9	0.2	6.8	7.1	7.0	5.7	3.37
*****	Sundaram Low Duration	3581.2	463	1.2	0.4	6.5	6.9	6.8	5.7	2.81
*****	Baroda BNP Paribas Low Duration	41.5	305	1.0	0.3	6.6	6.8	6.8	5.6	4.94
*****	LIC MF Low Duration	41.0	1867	1.2	0.3	6.5	6.8	6.8	5.6	2.77

DEBT - MONEY MARKET FUNDS										
*****	Nippon Ind Money Market	4318.6	21699	0.4	0.2	7.2	7.4	7.4	6.3	-
*****	UTI Money Market	3210.0	20008	0.2	0.1	7.2	7.4	7.5	6.3	-
*****	Aditya Birla SL Money Manager	384.8	28816	0.4	0.2	7.1	7.4	7.4	6.3	-
*****	Axis Money Market	1489.4	22670	0.3	0.2	7.2	7.4	7.5	6.3	-
*****	ICICI Pru Money Market	395.0	35025	0.4	0.2	7.2	7.4	7.5	6.2	-
*****	Kotak Money Market	4672.8	32870	0.4	0.2	7.1	7.4	7.4	6.2	-
*****	Baroda BNP Paribas Money Market	1433.4	4579	0.4	0.2	7.0	7.2	7.1	5.8	-
*****	Franklin Ind Money Market	52.2	3898	0.3	0.1	7.2	7.4	7.4	6.1	-
*****	HDFC Money Market	5946.7	34063	0.4	0.2	7.1	7.4	7.4	6.2	-
*****	PGIM India Money Market	1377.8	203	0.5	0.2	6.8	7.0	7.1	5.8	-
*****	Sundaram Money Market	15.6	2062	0.3	0.2	7.1	7.3	7.3	6.0	-
*****	Tata Money Market	4912.7	33558	0.4	0.2	7.1	7.4	7.4	6.3	-
*****	DSP Savings	54.7	8863	0.4	0.2	6.8	7.0	7.1	5.9	-

bl rating	Scheme Name	Latest NAV (₹)	Latest Corpus (₹ Cr)	Expense Ratio (%)		Trailing Returns (%)				AA & Below
				Regular	Direct	1 Year CAGR	2 Year CAGR	3 Year CAGR	5 Year CAGR	
★ ★	HSBC Money Market	27.5	5437	0.3	0.2	7.0	7.2	7.2	5.8	-
★ ★	Invesco India Money Market	3165.8	5862	0.4	0.2	6.9	7.1	7.2	5.9	-
★ ★	SBI Savings	43.0	37079	0.7	0.3	6.8	7.0	7.0	5.8	-
★ ★	Bandhan Money Market	41.9	15694	0.4	0.1	7.1	7.2	7.0	5.7	-
★	Edelweiss Money Market	29.5	2745	0.6	0.1	6.6	6.8	6.7	5.4	-
DEBT - SHORT DURATION FUNDS										
★ ★ ★ ★	ICICI Pru Short Term	62.5	22707	1.1	0.5	7.5	7.6	7.6	6.5	10.34
★ ★ ★ ★ ★	UTI Short Duration	32.8	3188	0.8	0.4	7.0	7.2	7.3	7.0	7.84
★ ★ ★ ★	Aditya Birla SL Short Term	49.3	9748	1.0	0.4	7.3	7.5	7.5	6.3	11.36
★ ★ ★ ★	Axis Short Duration	32.1	11709	0.9	0.4	7.6	7.7	7.6	6.2	11.66
★ ★ ★ ★	HDFC Short Term Debt	33.2	7416	0.7	0.4	7.4	7.7	7.7	6.3	8.23
★ ★ ★ ★	Nippon Ind Short Duration	54.8	8684	0.9	0.4	7.5	7.7	7.6	6.2	7.60
★ ★ ★ ★	Bandhan Short Duration	59.1	10155	0.8	0.3	7.0	7.4	7.4	5.9	-
★ ★ ★	Baroda BNP Paribas Short Duration	30.2	277	1.1	0.4	7.0	7.2	7.3	5.9	1.82
★ ★ ★	HSBC Short Duration	27.4	4311	0.7	0.3	7.2	7.4	7.2	5.7	-
★ ★ ★	Kotak Bond Short Term	53.9	17558	1.1	0.4	6.9	7.2	7.2	5.8	-
★ ★ ★	Mirae Asset Short Duration	16.2	553	1.1	0.2	6.8	7.1	7.0	5.7	0.91
★ ★ ★	SBI Short Term Debt	33.3	17219	0.9	0.4	7.3	7.5	7.4	5.9	5.97
★ ★ ★	Sundaram Short Duration	45.8	198	0.7	0.3	7.0	7.4	7.3	6.0	2.53
★ ★	Canara Robeco Short Duration	26.2	426	1.0	0.4	6.4	6.8	6.7	5.3	-
★ ★	DSP Short Term	48.1	3690	0.9	0.4	6.8	7.2	7.1	5.7	-
★ ★	Invesco India Short Duration	3684.7	1341	1.1	0.4	7.0	7.1	7.2	5.6	4.33
★ ★	Tata Short Term Bond	49.3	3282	1.2	0.3	6.3	6.8	6.9	5.5	-
★	Groww Short Duration	2149.7	99	1.0	0.3	6.9	6.8	6.4	5.0	-
★	LIC MF Short Duration	15.0	260	1.2	0.4	6.7	7.0	6.9	5.2	4.07
-	BOI Short Term Income	27.6	286	1.0	0.5	6.6	7.7	7.3	10.2	6.31
-	MahI Manu Short Duration	13.2	89	1.3	0.4	6.8	7.1	7.0	-	15.62

Calvin Christ of MasterCard wins *businessline* Cerebration Corporate Quiz 2026 in a nail-biting grand finale

FINISHING IN STYLE. Preetham Upadhyia from Barclays, Chennai, finished as first runner-up, while Zaman Khan from Q Company, Kochi is the second runner-up

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Calvin Christ of MasterCard, New Delhi, clinched the top spot at the 22nd edition of The Hindu *businessline* Cerebration Corporate Quiz 2026 held at the Bombay Stock Exchange in Mumbai. Preetham Upadhyia from Barclays, Chennai, finished as the first runner-up, while Zaman Khan from Q Company, Kochi, took the second runner-up position in a nail-biting finish.

The event, presented by JK Tyre, powered by IndianOil and held in association with BSE, saw participation nearly double last year's 3,400. The other three finalists were Alagarsamy AP from Toyota Financial Services, Bengaluru; Naveen Kumar B from Sai Mitra Constructions, Hyderabad; and Meghashyam Shirodkar from HT Media, Mumbai.

PARTICIPATION SOARS Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor of *businessline*, underscored the quiz's growing stature: "The bl Cerebration Quiz has a well-earned reputation of being one of the most popular and toughest events on the corporate quiz calendar of the country... The popularity of the quiz will be evident from the fact that 6,000+ avid quizzers participated across regional qualification rounds this year." The finale unfolded across six rounds: the JK Tyre Passing Round, Words-mash, JK Tyre Around the Board, Buzz Break, IndianOil Passing Round, and Final Countdown. The two

passing rounds carried a distinctive lifeline: Contestants could invoke a one-time "immunity" option to double their points to 20 instead of the standard 10, with the negative marking capped at -5 should they get it wrong.

Christ led from the outset, with the contest tightening considerably towards the end.

Khan, who described his strategy as keeping his hand away from the buzzer unless confident, dramatically secured third place by correctly answering the final buzzer question. "I wanted to finish in the top three... my strategy was to not hit the buzzer even if there was a chance unless I was going for 70-30," Khan said.

Upadhyia, representing Chennai, noted how fiercely competitive the format was, saying that the contest was so close that every single point mattered right through to the final stages.

Christ, the youngest on the dais, scored a perfect 20 out of 20 in the preliminary round, too. "This is my first shot at the *businessline* quiz... it could have gone either way," he said, adding that the BSE venue made the experience particularly special.

NEW FORMATS Quiz Master Venkatesh Srinivasan, representing Nexus Consulting, noted that two of the six rounds were new formats introduced this season. "We thought one of the rounds might actually be too easy but the round actually tripped up the quizzers on



(From left) Satish Mendon, National Head, Events and Activations, The Hindu; Anil Malik, Business Head, West, The Hindu; Vaidyanathan N, Assistant Vice -President, Head of Circulation and Sales and Distribution, The Hindu; Zubeen Garg, Chief General Manager, Marketing Head office, IndianOil Corporation; Janaki Krishnan, Head of businessline Mumbai bureau; Girish Jain, Executive Director, Marketing Head office, IndianOil; Alagarsamy AP from Toyota Financial (finalist); Meghashyam Shirodkar from HT Media (finalist); Thomas K Thomas, Managing Editor, *businessline*; Calvin Christ from MasterCard (winner); Naveen Kumar B from Sai Mitra Constructions (finalist); Quiz Master Venkatesh Srinivasan; Preetham Upadhyia from Barclays (first runner up); Melbin Verghese, ZSM - West, JK Tyre & Industries Ltd; Vinayak, RSM - West, JK Tyre; and Zaman Khan from Q Company (second runner up)



Participants fielding the questions



Quiz Master Venkatesh Srinivasan



A section of the audience

stage," he said. He also pointed to the camaraderie among the six finalists, all part of India's wider quizzing community, as a hallmark of the event. "The joy is in playing the sport and playing it fair," he added.

Distinguished guests at the event included Girish Jain, Executive Director (Corporate Communications and Branding), IndianOil; Melbin Verghese, ZSM - West, JK Tyre & Industries Ltd; and Vinayak, RSM - West, JK Tyre & Industries Ltd.

MUMBAI ROUND Earlier in the day, the Mum-

bai regional finale, from which Shirodkar qualified, was also conducted at the same venue. The prelims featured 20 questions, followed by four competitive rounds spanning business history to contemporary

corporate and popular culture, drawing strong audience engagement. The Mumbai regional was decided only after a tiebreaker, reflecting the razor-thin margins that defined the competition at every stage.

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Gem & jewellery sector all smiles post US tariff ruling

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The US Supreme Court's decision to strike down President Donald Trump's unilateral tariff has come as a major relief for India's gem and jewellery industry reeling under weak demand amid high gold prices.

The export duty on gem and jewellery industry will come down to 10 per cent (in a decision on Saturday morning, Trump announced raising the levy to 15 per cent) from the prevailing 18 per cent, making exports from India more attractive.

Last August, the US imposed a 60 per cent tariff on many Indian goods, including gems and jewellery comprising a 10 per cent base, 25 per



cent reciprocal and 25 per cent additional duty. The high duty applies to polished diamonds, gemstones and finished jewellery and severely impacted both exports and margins. However, the recent trade negotiations brought the duty down to 18 per cent.

Exports from India in the

first 10 months of this fiscal were down one per cent at \$23.19 billion, largely due to the 60 per cent tariff levied by the US.

During this period, exports to India's biggest market, the United Arab Emirates, increased 24 per cent, while shipments to Hong Kong increased 33 per cent. There was over 36 per cent growth in exports to Australia and France.

'SUPPLY VACUUM'

Colin Shah, MD, Kama Jewellery, said the US top court verdict will address the demand supply vacuum that was created due to the duties levied earlier as exporters were finding it difficult to maintain trade given the steep tariff rates.

While the new development is a change in the paradigm, it

is also true that exporters still have to walk a tight rope. The positive aspect is that non-exempt finished jewellery categories will continue to experience pressures on costs. Exporters will have to be more astute in their planning, scheduling and classification to avoid any unnecessary hassles, he added.

Anil Rego, Founder and Fund Manager at Right Horizons PMS, said the steep reduction in duties from earlier levels of about 50 per cent along with zero-duty access for specific categories such as silk and diamonds meaningfully enhances cost competitiveness in the sizeable US market.

At a sector level, textiles and gems and jewellery stand out as the most direct and near-term gainers from the easing of tariffs, he said.

India aiming to build a robust semicon manufacturing ecosystem: Modi

S Ronendra Singh
Jewar (Uttar Pradesh)

India Chip, the 60:40 joint venture between HCL Group and Taiwan's Foxconn facility in Uttar Pradesh, will help in making the State a technology 'powerhouse', Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Saturday adding that India is aiming for self-reliance in chip manufacturing, and the focus remains on building a robust semiconductor ecosystem.

The JV company is setting up India's first Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) facility in the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) at Jewar, UP, at an investment of ₹3,700 crore. The facility is expected to be operational by 2028.

Modi said the nation is already moving forward with the massive



UP CM Yogi Adityanath, Union IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, HCL Group Chairperson Roshni Nadar Malhotra, and other dignitaries at the groundbreaking ceremony of HCL-Foxconn Semiconductor JV India Chip

programme to strengthen India's semiconductor ecosystem. "India is now striving to stand alongside the world's top nations in providing the processing power required to run the modern world and is working simultaneously on software and hardware aspects," he said. The India Chip's state-of-the-art facility

will produce display driver chips and is expected to create over 3,500 direct and indirect jobs, build local supply chains, and attract ecosystem partners. The foundation stone was laid by the Prime Minister (virtually) in the presence of UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and Union IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw.

IIT Madras offers BS in Management and Data Science

Our Bureau
Chennai

Indian Institute of Technology Madras (IIT Madras) on Saturday launched a Bachelor of Science (BS) in Management and Data Science, an interdisciplinary undergraduate programme offered by the Department of Management Studies. This is designed to equip learners with expertise in business decision-making, quantitative thinking, and data-driven problem solving.

Graduates will receive a Bachelor of Science degree from IIT Madras, carrying the same academic recognition as any other degree offered by the Institute.

ENTRY REQUIREMENTS

The programme is open to anyone who has completed Class 12 or an equivalent qualification, including diploma holders. There is no age limit or seat restriction. Learners can pursue the programme as a standalone degree, or alongside another academic programme, or



V Kamakoti, Director, IIT Madras, flanked by Rajiv C Lochan, MD and CEO, Sundaram Finance, and Gangapriya Chakraverti, India Site Head and MD, Ford Motor. BUJOY GHOSH

while being employed, said a release.

Candidates are admitted either through an in-house qualifier or by being eligible to appear for JEE Advanced. The first batch starts from June. The last date to apply is May 31, the release said.

FLEXIBLE LEARNING

This the fourth BS programme to be launched by IIT Madras after BS in Data Science and Applications; BS in Electronic Systems and BS Aeronautics & Space Tech. "IIT is for all. Through such BS courses, we want to reach out to a large number of students of various ages,"

V Kamakoti, Director, IIT Madras, said at the launch.

Gangapriya Chakraverti, India Site Head and Managing Director, Ford Motor Company, said that today data is the most valuable asset for any company.

Rajeev Lochan, Managing Director and CEO, Sundaram Finance, said, "We live in a time where two powerful forces are at work simultaneously. First the world of technology, digital and data is disrupting every industry. The second is the imperative for lifelong learning. We just need to stay ahead of the curve all the time."

PhonePe launches AI-powered voice, text search, payment feature

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

PhonePe has launched an AI-powered natural language search feature built using Microsoft Foundry. This feature enables users initiate and complete in-app tasks via natural language text or voice commands, adding convenience to the platform's overall experience. The feature uses capabilities enabled by Microsoft Foundry to replace traditional navigation with intent-based routing, directly guiding users to their intended destination.

For instance, a request such as "Pay Hemant 20 rupees" automatically launches the payment interface with the recipient pre-selected or displays all relevant contacts named Hemant. Similarly, commands such as "Recharge FASTag" or "Gold price" navigate the user to the appropriate page with the relevant information or transactional options. Beyond simple transactions, this feature

captures insights and can interpret whether a user is trying to make a payment, or reach support for help. All of this is achieved via a hybrid model that combines local on-device and cloud inferencing, while keeping all processing secure and ensuring privacy with no personal or transactional data leaving the PhonePe environment. Speaking on the launch, Rahul Chari, Founder, Whole-time Director and CTO, PhonePe, said: "For years, payment apps have been built as utilitarian tools, optimized for transactions and not people. And we believe intelligence at the edge is the future and the most thoughtful way to deliver real value without compromising on privacy or security."

Puneet Chandok, President, Microsoft India and South Asia said: "Microsoft Foundry provides the underlying capabilities that help innovators like PhonePe build secure, scalable and human-centred products for millions."

Govt, military leaders to deliberate at first defence-space meet DEFSAT 2026

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Top government and military leadership will converge at the 4th edition of DEFSAT 2026 for three days from February 24 to deliberate over structured policy coordination, capability road-mapping and doctrine development which will help shape scenarios for IndSpaceX 4.0, India's first industry-led defence-space tabletop exercise.

It will also formalise creation of the Strategic Defence Space Group, a high-level multi-stakeholder body to support the country's long-term military space preparedness. More than 500 participants from 20 plus countries, over 80 speakers and representations from more than 60 organisations will mark the defence-space dialogue at the event, said the organisers.

DEFSAT, with the theme 'Space at the Core of National Security,' will have 13 sessions from strategic doctrine and resilience to industrial cooperation and doctrine implementation.



Key confirmed participants for the seminar include Lt Gen Rajiv Ghai, Deputy Chief of Army Staff (Strategy); Air Vice Marshal Manu Midha, Director General of the Defence Space Agency (DSA); Sanjay Bahl, Director General, CERT-In; and Vinayak Godse, CEO, Data Security Council of India.

Top leadership expected to join, include the Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Vice Chief of the Air Staff Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor, Vice Chief of the Naval Staff Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan, and senior Tri-Services leadership such as Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit. Speaking ahead of the event, Subba Rao Pavuluri,

President, SatCom Industry Association-India, said: "Globally, more than 50 countries now operate military or dual-use satellites, and space has become central to deterrence and operational readiness."

The event will also feature an exhibition showcasing India's and the global defence-space ecosystem.

businessline.

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